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REAL WORK. HUMAN SKILLS.
A WORLD OF OPPORTUNITY.

THE INTERNSHIP PLAYBOOK™

Land It. Learn It. Build What Comes Next.



A practical guide and workbook for interns
and the employers helping them learn, contribute, and grow.

JAIME LANE

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A note to the person opening this book

You might be excited. You might be terrified. You might have practiced saying "Nice to meet you" in the car and then forgotten your own name at reception.

Welcome. You are in the right book.

An internship is often described as a chance to gain experience. That sounds simple until someone says, "Use your initiative," and you realize nobody explained where initiative lives, whether it requires a password, or who approves it.

This book helps you move from wondering to asking, from asking to practicing, and from practicing to showing what you can do. It also asks something of your employer: teach the work, explain its purpose, protect the people doing it, and create room for growth.

You do not have to arrive as a finished professional. You do need to participate in becoming one. That means curiosity, reliable effort, honest communication, respect, and a willingness to learn. Your employer needs those things too.

Work is part of a life. It should help you build skills, relationships, stability, contribution, and possibilities. It should not require you to disappear as a person.

Let's build an experience that leaves you with more than a temporary badge and a strong opinion about the break-room refrigerator.

A note to employers, supervisors, and partners

If your current internship plan is "They start Monday; we'll think of something," this book is for you too.

An intern is not spare capacity with a school calendar. A person needs a supervisor, clear responsibilities, appropriate training, safe boundaries, feedback, and work that connects to learning. You need a manageable system that makes those things possible without inventing the program every morning.

Use the employer sections alongside the intern chapters. Do not make the intern responsible for repairing a poorly designed placement. When an experience is confusing, examine the instructions, access, workload, and supervision before deciding the person lacks initiative.

The goal is shared: useful contribution now, stronger capability next, and an honest view of what could come after.

How to use the book

Each chapter includes a practical lesson, a fictional situation, words you can borrow, a workbook exercise, and an employer action. Write privately where appropriate. You may discuss selected answers with your supervisor; you do not have to hand over personal reflections, health details, or family circumstances to prove commitment.

Use the tools repeatedly. A first answer is a starting point, not a verdict. Revisit your goals after you experience actual work.

Suggested rhythm: Read one chapter, try one behavior, complete one tool, and discuss one useful observation each week. Short placements can combine chapters. Extended placements can repeat them with harder tasks. Safety and reporting information belongs before any assigned work, regardless of the reading schedule.

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1. Who are you before the job title?

Your starting portrait

INTERESTS: what draws me in?

SKILLS: what can I demonstrate?

VALUES: what matters to me?

CONDITIONS: what helps me learn?

A job title tells people where you sit in an organization. It does not explain what matters to you, how you learn, what you enjoy, or the kind of life you hope to build.

Before asking “What career should I choose?” ask “What do I want to learn about myself through work?” Maybe you like solving puzzles but dislike sitting alone all day. Maybe you enjoy helping people but need time to recover after constant conversation. Maybe you want dependable hours because you also care for a family member. Those observations matter.

Separate four things: interests, current skills, values, and conditions. An interest is something you want to explore. A skill is something you can practice and demonstrate. A value helps you decide what feels worthwhile. A condition helps you participate effectively: transportation, schedule, access, instructions, equipment, or support.

You can admire a profession without enjoying its daily tasks. You can also discover satisfying work in a role you had never heard of. The internship is a place to investigate, not a ceremony where you must announce your permanent destiny.

Real-world moment: “I’m supposed to love this”

Jordan enters a marketing internship because everyone says Jordan is creative. Designing social posts is enjoyable. Managing approval schedules is less enjoyable. Interviewing customers turns out to be the best part.

Jordan has not failed at marketing. Jordan has gathered evidence: creative work may be most satisfying when it involves people and research. The next conversation could explore customer insights, account management, community engagement, or product research.

Words you can borrow

“I’m learning that I enjoy interviewing people and organizing their ideas. Could I observe a project that uses those skills?”

Workbook: Your starting portrait

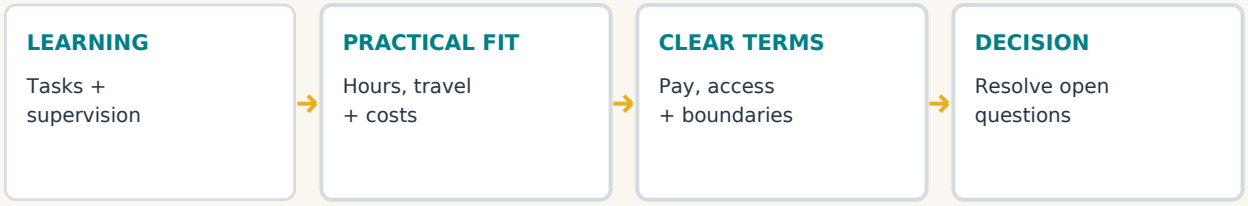
Prompt	Your response
A problem I enjoy helping solve	_____
Something I do well, with a real example	_____
Something I want to practice	_____
Three values I want work to support	_____
Conditions that help me learn	_____
A practical constraint I need to plan around	_____
A career assumption I want to test	_____
A question I hope this experience answers	_____

Try this: Describe one strength without using “hardworking,” “passionate,” or “team player.” Tell a short story instead. A sentence with evidence does more work than six impressive adjectives wearing a trench coat.

Employer action: Ask what the intern wants to explore. Do not require private personal disclosures. Agree on two or three learning goals that match real opportunities you can support.

2. Choosing an opportunity that can actually teach you

Choose the experience, not just the logo.



Ask for written clarity and appropriate review before committing.

A famous company can offer a weak internship. A small organization can offer excellent supervision. Evaluate the experience, not just the logo.

Look for a named supervisor, understandable tasks, clear hours and location, compensation terms, learning opportunities, training, a reporting route, and a realistic end date. Ask what past interns actually did. If there are no past interns, ask how the employer will support its first one.

Calculate the practical cost of participating: travel, parking, meals, equipment, clothing, internet, and time. Ask about assistance without apologizing for having a budget. Access to opportunity should not depend on pretending costs do not exist.

An internship title does not decide whether work may legally be unpaid. For for-profit employers, federal guidance discusses a fact-specific primary-beneficiary analysis; academic credit alone does not resolve the question. Other settings and state requirements need their own review. See Source 1. Employers should obtain qualified review rather than treating this book or a signed agreement as a legal classification test.

Real-world moment: “Exposure will be your compensation”

A company offers Riley an internship answering customer calls alone for most of each shift. Nobody can explain the training plan. The manager says, “You’ll learn by being here.”

Riley asks for supervision, compensation terms, and specific learning activities in writing. If the answers remain vague, Riley asks the school coordinator for help evaluating the placement. The opportunity needs scrutiny before acceptance.

Questions to ask before saying yes

- Who supervises me, and who helps when that person is absent?

- What might I produce during a normal week?

- What will I be taught before I do it?

- How will feedback work?

- What are the pay, schedule, travel, equipment, and expense arrangements?

- Are any tasks restricted by age, training, credentials, or policy?

- How do I raise a concern, including a concern about my supervisor?

- What happens if the placement is a poor fit or needs to end early?

Workbook: Opportunity decision

Opportunity: _____ Questions answered by: _____ Date: _____

What I can learn: _____

What I will contribute: _____

What participation will cost: _____

Support available: _____

Important unanswered questions: _____

My next step and deadline: _____

Employer action: Provide a written role summary before acceptance. Do not imply a guaranteed job, credential, or school credit unless the responsible authority has actually approved it.

3. Getting in: applications, interviews, and honest evidence

Tell an honest evidence story.

SITUATION	ACTION	RESULT	LEARNING
What was happening?	What did you do?	What changed or was made?	What would you improve?

Use verified examples. A useful output does not need an invented statistic.

You may not have much paid experience. You still have evidence of learning. A school project, team role, caregiving responsibility, community event, or part-time job can show organization, communication, persistence, or problem-solving.

Describe what you did, how you did it, and what happened. Do not invent numbers because a résumé article said every bullet needs one. “Created a sign-up sheet and confirmed volunteers before the event” is more useful than “Revolutionized stakeholder engagement” when the stakeholder was your cousin and the engagement was a text.

Customize applications around the actual role. Learn what the organization does, whom it serves, and why the internship interests you. Keep copies of the job description and your application.

In an interview, you can say you have not done something yet. Follow that with a relevant example of learning and a sensible question about training. Honesty gives the employer a starting point for support.

Real-world moment: “Tell me about a time you led”

Sam has never been team captain. Sam did coordinate rides for a group presentation when two classmates could not get to school early.

Sam explains the situation, the plan, the communication, and the result. Leadership includes noticing what the group needs and taking useful responsibility. It is not exclusively a title or a microphone.

Words you can borrow

“I haven’t used that system yet. In my last project I learned a new scheduling tool by practicing with sample data and asking for feedback. How do you train interns on this system?”

Workbook: Build three evidence stories

For each story, complete:

Situation: What was happening? _____

Responsibility: What was yours to do? _____

Action: What did you actually do? _____

Result: What changed, without exaggerating? _____

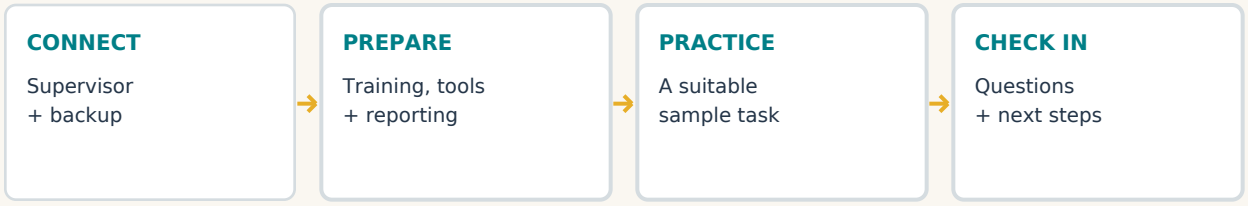
Learning: What would you repeat or improve? _____

Prepare one story about teamwork, one about learning, and one about recovering from a mistake. Practice speaking each in about a minute. Ask someone whether your role is clear.

Employer action: Evaluate evidence relevant to the role. Offer clear interview instructions and an accessible way to request adjustments. Do not reward only candidates who already know office vocabulary or have well-connected families.

4. The first week: belonging begins with clarity

A first week that makes sense.



Required training and authorization come before relevant work.

The first week should answer “Who helps me?”, “What am I allowed to do?”, “What matters here?”, and “What does good work look like?”

Arrive with the agreed schedule, contact information, required materials, and a plan for getting there. If access or instructions are missing, say so. You cannot demonstrate reliability in a system nobody has explained.

Write down names and responsibilities. Learn where information is stored, which communication channels are used, what constitutes an urgent issue, and how to record hours. Learn safety and reporting procedures before starting relevant work. Employer safety training must address the actual work and be understandable; a friendly tour is not the whole safety plan. See Source 2.

There is a difference between normal first-day awkwardness and an unsafe or unsupported placement. Forgetting the printer name is awkward. Being asked to operate equipment without training is a reason to pause and seek help.

Real-world moment: The invisible intern

Avery starts remotely. The supervisor has meetings all morning; Avery has no login and no task. Avery sends a short message listing the blocked access and asks for a temporary approved task. The supervisor assigns a sample-based orientation exercise and names a backup contact.

The lesson is shared: Avery communicates the barrier; the employer fixes the setup. Avery does not need to pretend productivity happened.

Workbook: My first-week map

Need	Name, location, or instruction	Still missing?
Supervisor and backup	_____	_____
Buddy or mentor	_____	_____
HR or designated people contact	_____	_____
Reporting route beyond supervisor	_____	_____
Emergency and safety procedures	_____	_____
Schedule, breaks, and attendance	_____	_____
Timekeeping and pay questions	_____	_____
Tools, permissions, and data rules	_____	_____
First task and review time	_____	_____

Employer action: Check comprehension with an explanation or supervised demonstration. “Any questions?” followed by silence is not proof that training worked.

5. What HR does - and how to ask for help

Build your support map

TASKS: supervisor + backup

PAY / HOURS: appropriate contact

SAFETY / CONDUCT: reporting routes

SCHOOL / PARTNER: if applicable

HR usually helps an organization manage employment processes: recruiting, onboarding, policies, pay and benefits administration, employee relations, training, accommodations, and other people-related responsibilities. The exact structure varies. A small employer may use an owner, outside provider, or designated contact instead of an HR department.

HR works for the organization. It is not your personal lawyer or a confidential therapist. That does not make it useless or automatically hostile. Learn its responsibilities, reporting process, and confidentiality limits so you can use it wisely.

Your supervisor usually clarifies assignments and priorities. Payroll or HR usually helps with pay administration. An approved accommodation contact handles requests through the employer's process. Safety concerns need the safety or reporting route. Harassment, discrimination, or retaliation concerns may require HR, another designated contact, a school coordinator, or an appropriate external agency, depending on the facts and coverage.

For serious concerns, do not assume you must confront the person first. EEOC guidance describes reporting options and protections against retaliation under the laws it enforces; applicability and deadlines need individualized review. See Source 3. Internal reporting may not preserve external deadlines.

Real-world moment: “Can this stay between us?”

Taylor wants to ask HR about repeated inappropriate comments. Before naming details, Taylor asks what confidentiality means and who may need to know. HR explains that it may need to act and cannot promise absolute secrecy. Taylor can then choose how to proceed with clearer expectations.

Words you can borrow

“I need guidance about a workplace concern. Before I share details, can you explain your role, confidentiality limits, the reporting process, and what follow-up I can expect?”

Workbook: My support routes

Task questions go to: _____

Pay or timekeeping questions go to: _____

Accommodation questions go to: _____

Safety concerns go to: _____

Conduct concerns go to: _____

If my usual contact is involved or unavailable: _____

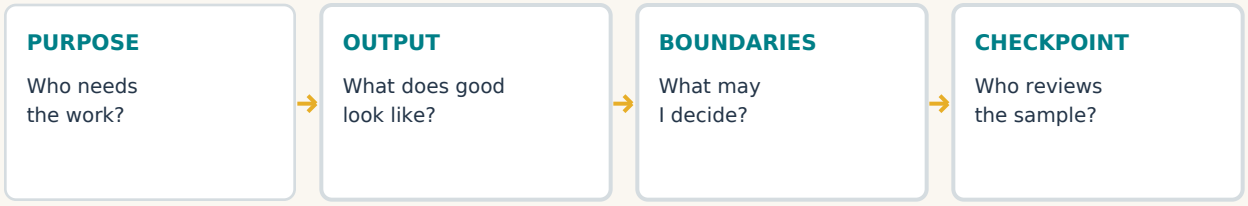
School/partner contact, if applicable: _____

Keep factual records through approved means. Record dates, actions, messages, impact, and whom you contacted. Do not secretly record people or take restricted files to a personal device as a default documentation strategy.

Employer action: Explain reporting routes in plain language and provide an alternative to the direct supervisor. Describe how information is handled, who responds, and how concerns about retaliation can be raised.

6. Turning assignments into meaningful tasks

Make the assignment clear before scaling up.



Confirm access, training, deadline, and approval before starting.

“Help with the event” is not a complete assignment. Neither is “Fix the spreadsheet,” although the spreadsheet may have strong opinions about needing help.

Before starting, understand the purpose, expected output, audience, deadline, standards, permissions, and review point. Ask for an example where possible. Repeat the assignment in your own words. A two-minute clarification can prevent two days of confident work on the wrong problem.

Break the work into steps. Estimate time, identify dependencies, and choose an early checkpoint. For unfamiliar or sensitive work, begin with a sample. Show the sample before scaling up.

Routine work can build useful skills when its purpose is explained and complexity grows. Repeated errands without learning, feedback, or a reasonable role connection should prompt a conversation about the placement design.

Real-world moment: Three bosses, one afternoon

Morgan receives a report due at 3 p.m., a customer list due at 4 p.m., and an urgent event request. Morgan cannot decide company priorities alone.

Morgan lists the tasks and estimates, then asks the designated supervisor to confirm the order and negotiate deadlines with the other requesters. Ownership means making the collision visible early.

Words you can borrow

“I have these three commitments and about four hours available. Which should come first, and which deadline can move? I’ll update the other requesters after you confirm.”

Workbook: Task agreement

Task / requester: _____

Purpose and person helped: _____

Deliverable and example: _____

Deadline / first checkpoint: _____

Quality requirements: _____

Allowed tools, data, and actions: _____

Training or access needed: _____

Steps and rough time estimates: _____

Reviewer / approval required: _____

What would require stopping or escalating: _____

Worked example: A hospitality intern drafts a guest-information card. The purpose is to reduce confusion about breakfast and checkout. The output is one draft using approved information, reviewed by the front-desk lead before printing. The intern may observe questions and use a blank template; the intern may not access guest records, change rates, or publish without approval. The first checkpoint is a rough draft after one hour.

Employer action: Attach a learning goal to the task - such as accurate information gathering or audience-focused writing - and plan feedback. Do not delegate responsibilities beyond the intern’s training, authorization, or legal eligibility.

7. Asking questions and communicating like a teammate

I’m stuck. Which route fits the situation?

- **RISK OR MISCONDUCT**
  Pause further risk; use the designated reporting or emergency route.
- **MISSING INSTRUCTIONS**
  Ask for the purpose, example, deadline, and review point.
- **MISSING ACCESS OR TRAINING**
  Tell your supervisor; use the backup contact if needed.
- **COMPETING PRIORITIES**
  List the commitments; ask the decision owner to choose.
- **ROUTINE WORK QUESTION**
  Explain what you tried and the specific help you need.

Report serious concerns promptly. Do not wait to perfect a message.

Questions are not evidence that you are incapable. They are tools for preventing avoidable mistakes. The most useful question makes the issue understandable and shows what kind of help you need.

For a routine question, state the goal, what you tried, where you are stuck, and the decision you need. For danger, misconduct, or sensitive data exposure, report promptly; do not delay while trying to make the perfect message.

Agree on channels and response expectations. Some workplaces use chat for quick updates, email for decisions, and a task system for progress. Other workplaces use a shift huddle and a paper log. Professional communication follows the actual environment.

A useful update answers: completed, next, blocked, and needed. Silence can look like progress until the deadline reveals otherwise.

Real-world moment: The mysterious “fine”

Lee sends a draft and receives “fine.” Lee does not know whether that means approved for publication or ready for another review. Lee asks, “Is this approved to publish, or should I hold it for final review?” That question protects both people.

Words you can borrow

“My goal is to organize these records by date. I checked the example and tested five rows, but two dates conflict. Which source should I use? I’m holding those rows until you confirm.”

Workbook: Rewrite the update

Vague: “Still working on it.”

Your useful version: _____

Vague: “I don’t get it.”

Your useful version: _____

Vague: “Nobody answered, so I guessed.”

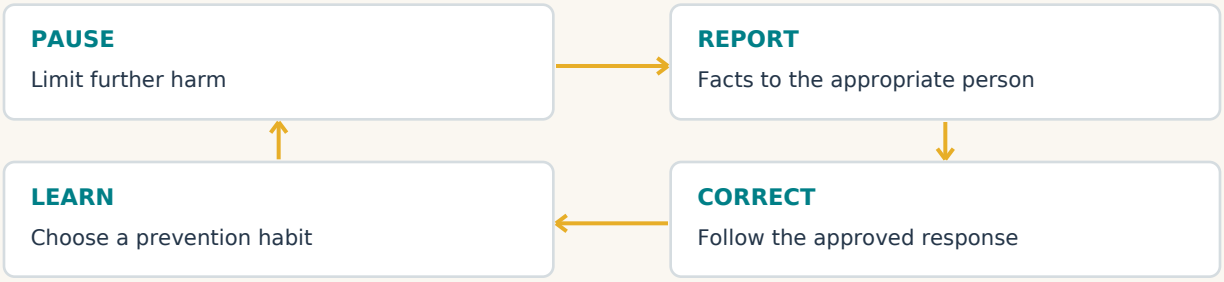
Your safer next step: _____

Daily update template: “Completed _____. Next _____. Blocked by _____. I need _____ by _____ to meet _____.”

Employer action: Set a backup contact and a rule for what to do while waiting. An intern should not have to guess whether to keep working, switch tasks, or stop.

8. Confidence, ownership, and the mistake you wish you could unsend

Own the mistake. Improve the process.



Report serious incidents promptly; do not wait until you can fix them alone.

Confidence grows when you collect evidence that you can learn, contribute, and recover. It is not the ability to sound certain about everything.

Ownership means understanding your responsibility, communicating progress, checking quality, and following through. It also means knowing when a decision belongs to someone else. It does not mean accepting blame for every problem, working unlimited hours, or hiding a mistake until you can privately repair it.

When something goes wrong, pause any action that could make it worse. Notify the appropriate person, state the facts, follow the correction process, and identify a prevention step. Avoid guessing about the impact or promising a fix you are not authorized to make.

Real-world moment: Wrong attachment

Casey emails an internal draft to the wrong recipient. It may contain restricted information. Casey immediately tells the supervisor and follows the organization’s incident process. Casey does not send five more messages, delete evidence, or decide independently that it is probably fine.

After the incident is addressed, Casey adopts a final check: recipient, attachment, permissions, and approval. The lesson is a repeatable habit, not a week of self-punishment.

Words you can borrow

“I sent the wrong attachment to __ at __. I have paused further messages. The file may contain __. Please advise the next step under our incident process. I’ll provide the facts and follow the approved response.”

Workbook: Ownership without self-erasure

My responsibility: _____

What I need permission or support for: _____

What happened, without excuses or assumptions: _____

Who needs to know: _____

Approved correction: _____

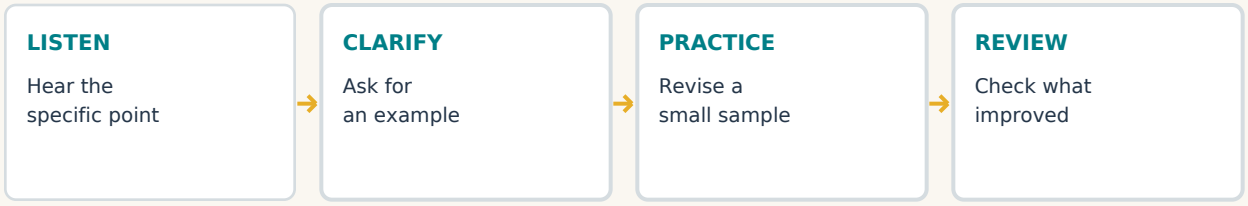
Prevention habit: _____

Evidence that I am improving: _____

Employer action: Respond proportionately. Investigate whether training, access controls, instructions, or review procedures contributed. Accountability and humane treatment belong together.

9. Feedback without losing yourself

Turn feedback into a next action.



Feedback concerns work and behavior; it does not define your worth.

Feedback is information about work or behavior. It is not a complete description of your worth.

Useful feedback identifies what happened, why it matters, and what to do differently. “You need to be more professional” leaves too much to interpretation. “Please send schedule changes before the shift so we can arrange coverage” gives you something to practice.

Listen, ask for an example, confirm the change, and try it. You can need time to process. You can also question feedback respectfully when facts are missing or instructions conflict. Being teachable does not require accepting humiliation, discrimination, or unsafe directions.

Real-world moment: “This isn’t what I wanted”

Drew’s supervisor rejects a report. Drew wants to defend the hours spent on it. Instead, Drew asks which part misses the purpose and requests a model. The supervisor realizes the desired audience was never explained. They agree on a shorter summary and a checkpoint before the next full draft.

Drew still revises the work. The supervisor also improves the instruction. Growth is allowed on both sides of the desk.

Words you can borrow

“Can you show me one example of the standard you want? I’ll revise the first section and check with you before changing the rest.”

Workbook: Feedback-to-action log

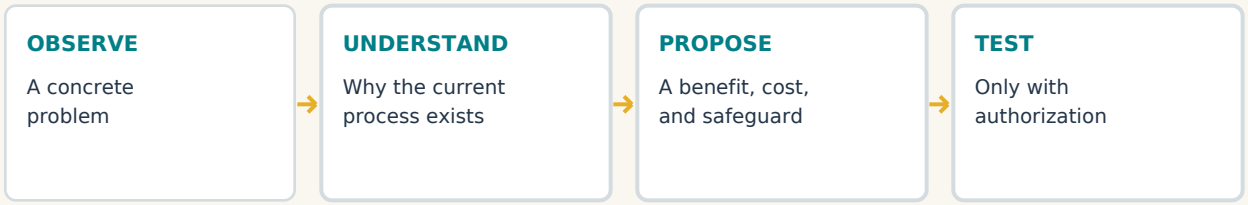
Date / task	Specific feedback	My next action	Review date	What changed
_____	_____	_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____	_____	_____

Reflection: What part of the feedback was useful? What needs clarification? What story did I tell myself that the person did not actually say? _____

Employer action: Give private, behavior-specific feedback with a realistic opportunity to improve. Ask the intern to explain the next step; do not confuse nodding with understanding.

10. Offering ideas people can use

Build an idea people can evaluate.



An attractive idea still needs context, evidence, and an approval route.

You do not need years of experience to notice a problem. You do need enough curiosity to understand why the current process exists.

Start with observation rather than accusation. “I noticed customers ask the same question repeatedly” opens a conversation. “Your system is outdated” often closes one.

Ask what has been tried. Identify the people affected, the benefit, the cost, the risks, and the approval needed. Propose a small reversible test where appropriate. Do not use real customer data, contact outsiders, change a production system, or spend money without authorization.

If an idea is declined, ask whether the barrier is timing, resources, evidence, risk, or fit. A useful idea may need different packaging. Some ideas simply are not suitable. You can learn from either result.

Real-world moment: The form everybody hates

Alex notices a duplicated field in an intake process. A coworker explains that one version serves an audit requirement. Alex proposes a mock-up using invented data that preserves the required field but reduces retyping. A process owner reviews it before any live change.

Alex bridges a fresh observation and existing knowledge. Nobody has to lose dignity for the process to improve.

Workbook: One-page idea proposal

Observed problem, with a concrete example: _____

Who is affected: _____

What I learned about the existing process: _____

Proposed change: _____

Benefit and how we would observe it: _____

Time, resources, risks, and safeguards: _____

Small test using approved materials: _____

Decision owner / permission requested: _____

Review date / stop condition: _____

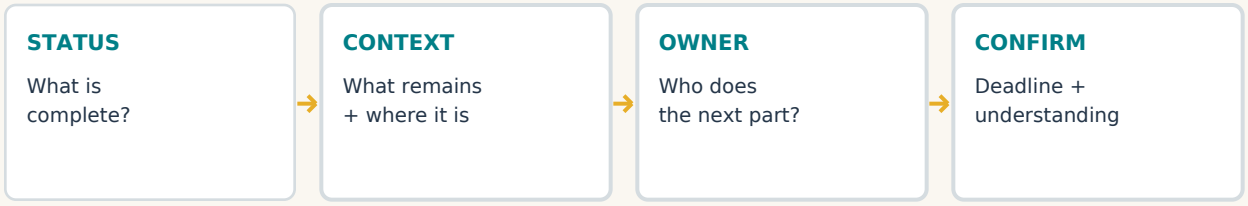
Words you can borrow

“Would you be open to reviewing a small idea? I noticed __. I learned __ from the current process. I could draft a sample for review without changing the live workflow.”

Employer action: Give ideas a decision route and close the loop. Credit the intern’s contribution where appropriate. Do not encourage initiative and then punish reasonable questions about improvement.

11. Relationships, teamwork, and sharing credit

A handoff is more than sending a file.



Make ownership visible; agree on changes before silently transferring work.

Relationships grow through repeated acts of reliability and interest. Learn names. Ask people what they do. Respect their time. Follow through. Thank them specifically.

You do not have to become the loudest person in the room. Quiet people can build strong relationships through preparation, thoughtful questions, and useful follow-up. Avoid treating networking as collecting people who might eventually do you a favor.

A mentor helps you understand and grow. A supervisor assigns and evaluates work. A buddy helps you navigate everyday details. One person may fill several roles, but do not assume everyone has authority to approve your decisions.

Good teamwork makes responsibilities visible. Agree on the output, owners, handoffs, review steps, and deadlines. Share credit accurately. Discuss missing contributions early enough to solve them.

Real-world moment: The presentation with one name

Two interns build a presentation. One presents it and says “I created this.” The other feels erased.

A repair sounds like: “I should have named your contribution. I’ll correct that in the follow-up and introduce the next section as our shared work.” Future presentations include a contribution note.

Workbook: Relationship map

Person / role	What I can learn	A respectful question	Follow-through
Supervisor	_____	_____	_____
Experienced coworker	_____	_____	_____
Person in an unfamiliar role	_____	_____	_____
Partner or school contact	_____	_____	_____

Ten-minute team exercise: Using a fictional event, agree on three deliverables, assign owners, identify a likely handoff failure, and design a check to prevent it. Then switch roles and ask which responsibilities became invisible.

Employer action: Introduce the intern across relevant roles. Explain that employees may decline or reschedule learning conversations. Make mentoring time feasible instead of adding it silently to overloaded schedules.

12. Conflict: handle the issue without becoming the issue

Prepare a useful conflict conversation

FACTS: what actually happened?

IMPACT: how did it affect the work?

REQUEST: what change would help?

ROUTE: conversation or escalation?

Conflict can mean different expectations, competing deadlines, uneven work, disrespect, or a serious conduct concern. The response depends on the issue.

For ordinary disagreements, separate what you observed from what you assumed. Describe the work impact and ask for a practical change. A private conversation may help if it feels appropriate and safe. When the issue involves safety, threats, discrimination, harassment, retaliation, or a significant power imbalance, use the designated reporting route rather than treating it as a peer communication exercise.

You are not required to mediate serious misconduct or prove you can tolerate it.

Real-world moment: “You always dump work on me”

Blair’s teammate sends incomplete files late. Blair starts typing a message about the teammate’s character, then stops.

A better message: “The last two files arrived after our agreed time and were missing the totals. That left me unable to complete the combined report. Can we confirm a checkpoint tomorrow and use the template before handoff?”

If the pattern continues, Blair brings dates, impacts, and prior attempts to the supervisor and asks for a clearer assignment plan.

Workbook: Conflict planner

Observed facts: _____

My interpretation, which may be incomplete: _____

Work impact: _____

Requested change: _____

Appropriate conversation or reporting route: _____

Support I need: _____

Follow-up date: _____

Role-play: One person describes a missed handoff; another explains a competing instruction from a different supervisor. A third person observes whether they discuss facts, ask questions, and identify a decision owner. Debrief the process, not anyone’s personality.

Employer action: Clarify competing instructions and intervene when needed. Do not label every complaint a lack of resilience. Avoid promising an outcome before reviewing the facts.

13. Professional etiquette in real life

Professional presence is a practice.



Judge relevant behavior, not clothing style, personality, or appearance.

Professional etiquette helps people work together with less confusion. It is not a demand to imitate one personality, accent, culture, body, or wardrobe budget.

Be prepared, communicate changes, follow relevant dress and safety requirements, respect boundaries, and use agreed channels. If a rule is unclear, ask what it means in practice. Employers should explain genuine role requirements and apply them fairly.

For meetings, learn the purpose, prepare your part, arrive as agreed, and record actions. For remote work, check equipment and ask about camera expectations rather than assuming. Accessibility and privacy needs may require a different arrangement.

For social events, attendance expectations, alcohol rules, transportation, and expenses should be clear. Do not assume a coworker wants personal comments or an after-hours connection because everyone is being friendly.

Humor works best when it includes people without targeting their identity, ability, age, appearance, background, or vulnerability. An awkward printer can be funny. Someone’s accommodation is not material.

Real-world moment: Late again, but not careless

Nico’s bus schedule changes. Nico informs the supervisor, explains the scheduling issue without oversharing, and asks whether the start time can shift. They agree on a plan. Reliability includes communicating real constraints; it is not pretending transportation never fails.

Words you can borrow

“My transportation schedule changed, and I may miss the current start time. Could we discuss an approved adjustment? I can reliably arrive at __ and want to plan this before my next shift.”

Workbook: My etiquette agreements

Arrival / remote check-in: _____

Dress and task-specific equipment: _____

Absence or delay notice: _____

Meeting preparation: _____

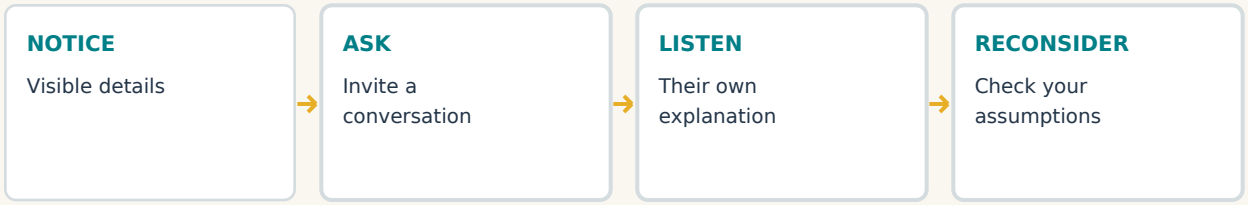
Personal phone and social-media rules: _____

Workplace humor boundary I will remember: _____

Employer action: Explain unwritten expectations. Address behavior specifically, without vague judgments such as “not a culture fit” when the actual issue can be described and taught.

Start with your shoes: The person beyond the job title

Observe first. Let the person tell the story.



Appearance opens a question; it does not establish personality or competence.

A 20-30 minute activity for interns, new employees, or a small team. Adapt the time and movement to the setting. The purpose is curiosity, connection, and understanding how personal expression meets the demands of a role - not evaluating anyone's body, budget, clothing, or hair.

First: right now. Not tonight. Not tomorrow. Right now.

Look at your shoes.

What are you wearing? Sneakers? Boots? Flats? Dress shoes? Something that has survived three semesters and one suspicious puddle?

Describe them before explaining them. Notice color, shape, material, fastening, and anything else you can actually see. If you are not wearing shoes, describe an accessory or another item you are comfortable discussing.

Now ask yourself: **Why did I choose these today?**

Maybe they fit the task. Maybe they are comfortable. Maybe they are your favorite. Maybe they were the only clean pair by the door. Maybe your workplace requires them. Maybe there is a reason you would rather keep private. You get to choose what you share.

The item is visible. Its meaning is not always visible.

> **Your shoes may have a story. They have not, however, submitted a résumé on your behalf.**

My shoes, my story

What I am wearing right now: _____

Three details I can observe: _____

Why I chose them today, if I want to share: _____

How they help me do today's work: _____

What someone might guess - and get wrong: _____

A question worth considering: Do I want my professional presence to communicate something? If so, what choices and behaviors help me express it? _____

Next: meet three colleagues

Choose a suitable moment and invite three willing colleagues into a short conversation. Ask your supervisor about timing and access if needed. Do not interrupt customer service, safety-sensitive work, a deadline, or someone who wants privacy.

You can move around, stay seated, or do this remotely. Nobody has to walk, stand, show their feet, appear on camera, or participate in a clothing activity. A person can discuss a chosen work item - a notebook, bag, tool, or accessory - instead.

Start with a greeting, not a silent inspection from toe to head.

"Hi, I'm _____. We're doing a short activity about the choices we bring to work. Would you mind a quick question about your shoes or another item you chose today?"

If they agree, try one of these:

- "What made you choose those today?"

- "Is there something about your work that influences what you wear?"

- "Do you have a favorite work item that makes the day easier?"

- "What do you wish new people understood about your role?"

A warm question is enough. Nobody needs to explain their health, finances, religion, cultural practices, or personal life. Accept a short answer or a polite decline and move on.

From toe to head - or head to toe

With a willing participant, broaden the conversation beyond shoes. They can choose whether to talk about clothing, a hairstyle, an accessory, or nothing appearance-related at all.

Notice ordinary visible details without rating them: a jacket, bright color, patterned shirt, tied-back hair, or required protective equipment. Then invite the person's explanation rather than writing your own biography for them.

A sneaker does not establish that someone is athletic. A suit does not establish that someone is more capable. Comfortable shoes do not reveal a medical condition. A dress does not tell you a person's career ambition. A hairstyle does not tell you whether someone is competent, reliable, or professional.

Ask about interests and lifestyle if they welcome the conversation. Let their answers supply the story.

"I like being comfortable because I'm on my feet a lot" is something the person told you. "They must be lazy because they dress comfortably" is a judgment you supplied. Learning to tell those apart is a workplace skill.

Notice the choice. Ask about the meaning. Let the person tell the story.

Three-colleague connection page

Use first names or initials with permission. These are personal learning notes, not employee profiles or a performance assessment. Do not record sensitive disclosures. You can complete the activity with fictional characters if preferred.

Conversation	Colleague 1	Colleague 2	Colleague 3
First name/initial or fictional role	_____	_____	_____
Shoes or chosen item: visible description	_____	_____	_____
Other style detail they chose to discuss	_____	_____	_____
What I already knew from working together	_____	_____	_____
What they actually told me about the choice	_____	_____	_____
How they described their role or daily tasks	_____	_____	_____

Conversation	Colleague 1	Colleague 2	Colleague 3
Interest or preference they volunteered	_____	_____	_____
One assumption I reconsidered	_____	_____	_____
One useful thing I learned	_____	_____	_____

Example: The sneakers and the spreadsheet

An intern notices that Rowan wears sneakers with office clothes. The intern privately guesses Rowan must be a runner.

During a willing conversation, Rowan explains: “I visit three departments most days, and these make that easier.” Rowan also enjoys drawing and has never liked running.

The shoes helped open a conversation. The conversation corrected the guess.

Later the intern notices Rowan calmly clarifying a deadline, helping a coworker, and giving credit to another person’s work. Those behaviors provide useful evidence about Rowan’s professional presence. The shoe brand does not.

Professional presence: what can we actually learn?

Appearance may reflect personal expression, workplace requirements, practical needs, or circumstances we do not know. Professional etiquette is better explored through behavior and relevant task expectations.

Topic	A useful question or observation
Role needs	What clothing or equipment does this task require, and why?
Personal expression	What does the person choose to share about their style?
Communication	Do they listen, clarify, and use respectful language?
Reliability	Do they follow through or communicate changes?
Teamwork	Do they help with appropriate handoffs and share credit?
Boundaries	Do they respect a person’s time, privacy, and choices?
Safety	Are task-specific requirements explained and followed?

A polished outfit cannot compensate for disrespect. An informal outfit does not cancel good judgment. Ask your supervisor about actual role requirements instead of grading colleagues against your own preferences.

The thought-provoking part

1. What did I observe, what did I assume, and what did the person actually tell me?
2. Did I connect style with competence before I had evidence?
3. How did my own clothing preferences influence my first impression?
4. What surprised me about the person’s work or interests?
5. What did their behavior tell me that their appearance could not?
6. What can I do to make it easier for a new colleague to feel welcome?
7. How can my own choices support the work while still feeling like me?

My biggest learning: _____

One assumption I will slow down next time: _____

One relationship-building action I will try this week: _____

Facilitator and employer notes

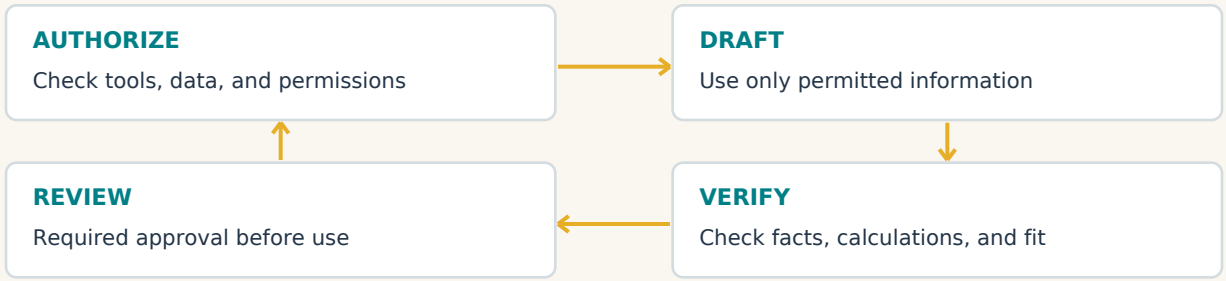
Explain the purpose before inviting participation. Use self-description and willing conversation, not public appearance critiques. Provide a non-appearance alternative. Do not photograph colleagues, distribute their notes, or collect personal explanations as a condition of participation. Avoid comments about attractiveness, bodies, cost, identity, or whether someone “looks professional.”

Debrief by asking what people learned about listening and assumptions. Discuss actual dress, protective-equipment, and safety requirements separately through the workplace’s established process. Do not use the exercise to enforce subjective style preferences or evaluate staff.

Closing line: “We started with shoes. We ended with a person. That is a much better way to begin a working relationship.”

14. Technology, privacy, and responsible AI

An approved AI workflow still needs judgment.



Report data exposure promptly. Do not enter protected data into unapproved tools.

Access is not permission to use information however you want. Learn what data is restricted, where it may be stored, which tools are approved, and who authorizes sharing.

Use approved accounts and devices. Do not share passwords, bypass permissions, install unapproved software, or move work into a personal account for convenience. Report suspicious messages through the employer’s process. Verify unusual payment, login, or data requests using a trusted channel.

AI can help with approved brainstorming, practice, or drafting. It can also produce convincing errors and expose information if used carelessly. Ask which tools and uses are allowed. Keep protected information out of unapproved systems. Check facts, calculations, sources, tone, and policy compliance. Disclose assistance when the organization requires it. You remain responsible for the work you submit.

Real-world moment: The impressive imaginary policy

Harper asks an AI tool to draft an onboarding FAQ. The draft confidently invents a leave policy. Harper compares every statement to approved source documents, removes unsupported claims, and sends the draft for review. The tool saved some drafting time; it did not become the HR department.

Workbook: Before I use a tool

Task and approved tool: _____

Information I may use: _____

Information I must exclude: _____

Permission or disclosure required: _____

How I will verify the output: _____

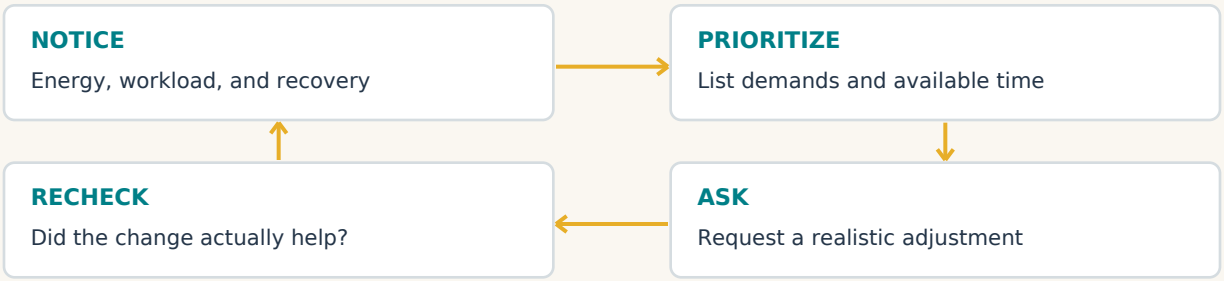
Who reviews it before use: _____

Practice: Use fictional information to draft a meeting agenda. Identify three ways the draft could be inaccurate or unsuitable. Edit it, then explain what you verified.

Employer action: Provide a usable policy and approved alternatives. Explain examples of prohibited data. Use practice data during training and review access when duties change or the placement ends.

15. Wellbeing, happiness, and a life outside the badge

Notice the load. Adjust before overcommitting.



Private reflection stays private; persistent distress may need appropriate support.

A meaningful internship should help you learn about work and about the life you want work to support.

Happiness does not mean enjoying every minute. Some days involve repetition, uncertainty, or a task you would not choose. Look for a broader pattern: do you feel useful, respected, supported, and able to recover? Are you learning? Can you ask for help? Is your schedule workable?

Notice the difference between a learning stretch and an unsustainable load. Learning stretch includes clear expectations, support, and time to recover. An unsustainable load may involve repeated impossible deadlines, unsafe demands, or pressure to ignore agreed hours.

Ask for priority decisions before overcommitting. Use available breaks and support resources according to the applicable arrangements. Timekeeping should reflect actual work; do not quietly hide work to look efficient. Pay and hours questions belong with the appropriate employer contact and, when needed, qualified outside guidance.

You do not need to turn every emotional difficulty into a productivity project. An internship workbook is not treatment. If distress is persistent or serious, seek an appropriate trusted or professional support person. For immediate danger, use emergency assistance.

Real-world moment: “I’m free anytime”

Quinn says yes to every request, then works late while missing meals and class preparation. Quinn thinks this proves ambition. The supervisor initially does not realize the hours involved.

Quinn lists the actual workload and requests a priority conversation. The supervisor reduces tasks and clarifies hours. The problem required a work-design change, not a motivational quote.

Workbook: A private weekly check-in

Energy: What restored or drained me? _____

Learning: What became clearer? _____

Connection: When did I feel supported or isolated? _____

Workload: What needs renegotiation? _____

Life: What important commitment needs space? _____

Joy: What small moment made this week better? _____

Action: One support request or adjustment: _____

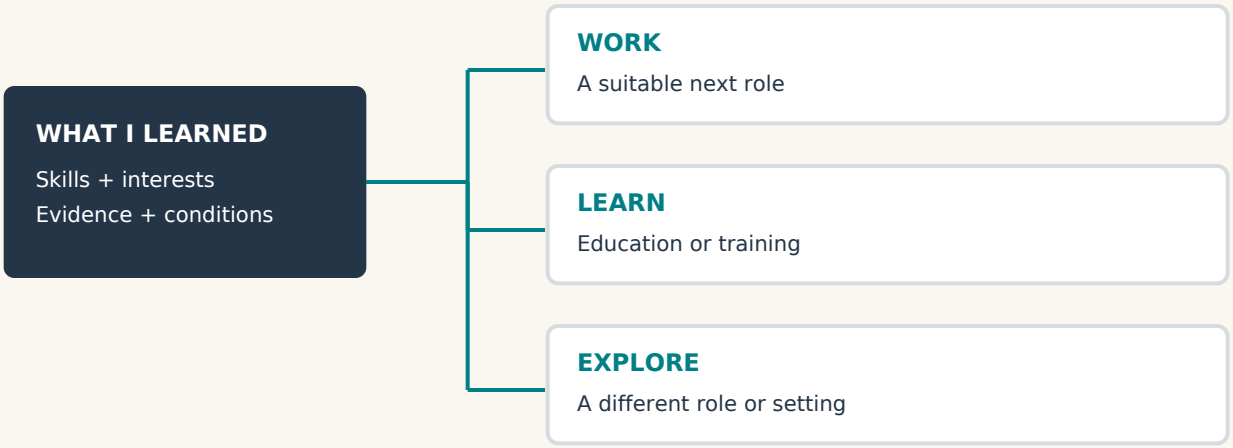
Words you can borrow

“I want to deliver good work within our agreed schedule. These assignments exceed the time available. Could we choose priorities and adjust the remaining work?”

Employer action: Treat workload and access barriers as operational issues. Do not score wellbeing reflections, require diagnoses in a learning journal, or equate boundary-setting with lack of commitment.

16. Career pathways: build options, not a single prediction

One experience. More than one next step.



Compare tasks, entry requirements, cost, access, and life fit.
These are exploration routes, not promises of jobs, credentials, or placements.

Career mapping atlas

Follow a connection from an interest or skill to a suitable learning task, then to roles you can investigate. These are possibilities to explore - not job matches, required qualifications, or guaranteed pathways.

MANUFACTURING + OPERATIONS

INTEREST / SKILL	TRY A SUITABLE TASK	ROLES TO EXPLORE
Finding patterns	Review approved sample quality records	Quality technician Process improvement
Organizing moving parts	Map a fictional inventory or production handoff	Production planning Supply chain coordination
Hands-on curiosity	Observe trained staff; discuss tools and systems	Maintenance technician Industrial automation

Illustrative exploration only: review task eligibility, supervision, and entry requirements.

Which connection surprises you? What would you need to observe, ask, or verify before taking a next step?

Career connections / 1

CONSTRUCTION + SKILLED TRADES

INTEREST / SKILL	TRY A SUITABLE TASK	ROLES TO EXPLORE
Visual / spatial thinking	Compare sample plans with supervised observation	Drafting / BIM Construction estimating
Planning and teamwork	Map a fictional project schedule and dependencies	Project coordination Site management
Hands-on problem-solving	Approved observation of different trade roles	Electrical / plumbing Other skilled-trade routes

Illustrative exploration only: review task eligibility, supervision, and entry requirements.

HEALTHCARE + SERVICE OPERATIONS

INTEREST / SKILL	TRY A SUITABLE TASK	ROLES TO EXPLORE
Explaining information	Draft an approved nonclinical information sheet	Patient access Health education roles
Accuracy and organization	Practice with fictional scheduling information	Scheduling / operations Health information roles
Interest in direct care	Approved role conversation or suitable observation	Nursing / allied health Other clinical pathways

Illustrative exploration only: review task eligibility, supervision, and entry requirements.

Career connections / 2

TECHNOLOGY + DIGITAL WORK

INTEREST / SKILL	TRY A SUITABLE TASK	ROLES TO EXPLORE
Logical problem-solving	Test a sample workflow in an approved sandbox	Software testing Software development
Explaining digital tools	Teach an approved tool using fictional data	IT support Technical training
Designing for people	Review a practice interface for clarity and usability	UX design / research Product operations

Illustrative exploration only: review task eligibility, supervision, and entry requirements.

HOSPITALITY + CUSTOMER EXPERIENCE

INTEREST / SKILL	TRY A SUITABLE TASK	ROLES TO EXPLORE
Listening and service	Practice fictional inquiries and escalation choices	Guest services Customer experience
Planning under pressure	Build an approved event-planning checklist	Event coordination Hospitality operations
Numbers and patterns	Review sample booking or purchasing information	Revenue operations Procurement / planning

Illustrative exploration only: review task eligibility, supervision, and entry requirements.

Career connections / 3

NONPROFIT + COMMUNITY WORK

INTEREST / SKILL	TRY A SUITABLE TASK	ROLES TO EXPLORE
Connecting people	Draft a volunteer brief from approved information	Volunteer coordination Community engagement
Writing and storytelling	Draft a fictional story; learn the consent process	Communications Development / fundraising
Measuring progress	Organize sample program outputs for review	Program coordination Program evaluation

Illustrative exploration only: review task eligibility, supervision, and entry requirements.

Which connection surprises you? What would you need to observe, ask, or verify before taking a next step?

Map the role you did not know existed

A title is the start of an investigation. Find out what people actually do, how the role connects to other work, and what entering it would require.

Build your own connection

INTEREST / SKILL I WANT TO TEST

SUITABLE TASK OR OBSERVATION

ROLE / DEPARTMENT TO EXPLORE

NEXT ACTION + CONTACT + DATE

Verify before choosing

What entry routes, qualifications, costs, age restrictions, or other requirements apply? Which employer, training provider, school, or professional authority can verify them? What did the experience reveal about my preferred tasks and life fit?

From project to portable skills

Connect something you actually did to evidence you can discuss in another role. A project may reveal several skills; it does not automatically qualify you for a different occupation.

PROJECT / EXPERIENCE	SKILLS PRACTICED	EVIDENCE TO VERIFY	OTHER WORK TO EXPLORE
Draft a welcome guide	Research, writing, audience awareness	Approved draft + revision	Communications, training, customer support
Plan a practice event	Scheduling, coordination, handoffs	Plan, checklist, feedback	Events, operations, project support
Investigate a sample process	Analysis, observation, improvement thinking	Process map + proposal	Quality, business analysis, operations
Teach an approved tool	Instruction, verification, listening	Lesson plan + feedback	Technical support, training, digital operations

Your skill-to-opportunity bridge

PROJECT I ACTUALLY WORKED ON

SKILLS + SPECIFIC ACTIONS

APPROVED EVIDENCE / FEEDBACK

ANOTHER ROLE TO INVESTIGATE

Explore your next step

A pathway is a sequence of possible next steps. It may include employment, further education, an apprenticeship, a credential, a different internship, or a change in direction. It is not always a ladder inside one company.

Learn the roles around you. Ask what skills they use, how people enter them, what qualifications are necessary, and what the everyday work feels like. Separate required credentials from preferred experience and informal advice. Verify program requirements and costs with the issuing institution or authority.

Transferable skills travel between industries. Organizing an event can teach scheduling, communication, budgeting, risk awareness, and follow-through. The transfer becomes credible when you explain your actions and evidence.

Do not choose a pathway solely because someone says it is prestigious. Consider tasks, conditions, costs, opportunities, and the life you want.

Real-world moment: The unexpected route

Emery enters a healthcare administrative internship expecting to pursue direct patient care. Emery enjoys scheduling, process improvement, and explaining information. A mentor introduces operations and health-information pathways. Emery now has more options, not less ambition.

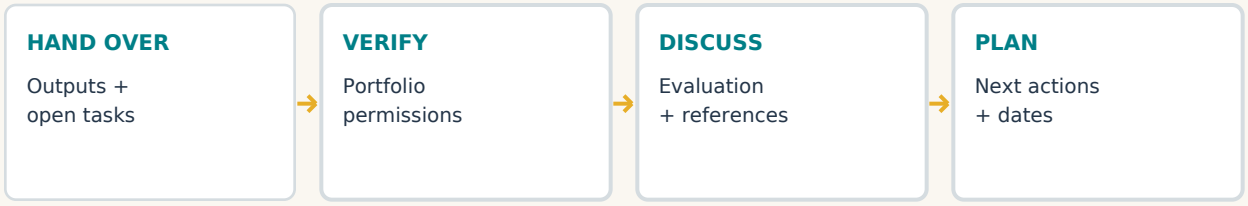
Workbook: Compare three next steps

Question	Option A	Option B	Option C
Daily tasks I would do	_____	_____	_____
Skills I already have	_____	_____	_____
Skills or credentials needed	_____	_____	_____
Time, cost, and access	_____	_____	_____
Schedule and life fit	_____	_____	_____
Source to verify requirements	_____	_____	_____
Small next experiment	_____	_____	_____

Employer action: Discuss pathways honestly. Do not imply there is a vacancy or guaranteed conversion when there is not. Offer useful introductions when appropriate and authorized.

17. Finishing well and building the next opportunity

Finish with evidence and direction.



Keep only authorized material. An internship does not guarantee a job offer.

The final week is not just a countdown. It is a chance to complete handoffs, recognize relationships, collect approved evidence, and decide what comes next.

Ask what may be included in a portfolio before copying anything. Often a sanitized summary, blank template, or fictional reconstruction can show a skill without exposing restricted information. Get permission for named client work, photos, testimonials, logos, and references where needed.

Describe your contribution accurately. A strong résumé statement identifies the task, action, and verified result. If a result was not measured, describe the output and purpose instead of inventing an improvement percentage.

Request a reference directly and give the person room to decline. Confirm contact details and any restrictions. Thank people for something specific they taught you.

Words you can borrow

“Would you be comfortable serving as a reference for my work on __? I can send a short summary of the role and the next opportunity. Please let me know what contact method you prefer.”

Workbook: My experience story

When I arrived, I could: _____

Now I can demonstrate: _____

Evidence I have permission to use: _____

Feedback I acted on: _____

A mistake and how I changed my process: _____

What I learned about my preferred work: _____

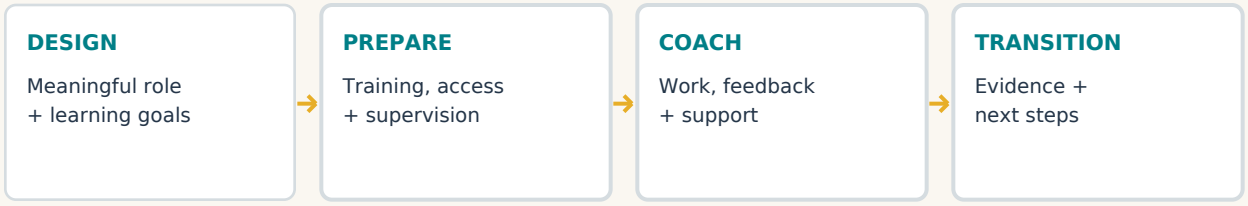
My next three actions and dates: _____

Exit checklist: Deliverables handed over; file locations documented; open tasks assigned; equipment returned; access closure arranged by employer; time and expenses submitted; evaluation completed; portfolio permissions confirmed; contacts and follow-up agreed.

Employer action: Provide an evidence-based evaluation and a clear statement about next opportunities. If there is no role available, say so respectfully. The intern’s work deserves closure even when a job offer is not possible.

18. The employer’s implementation playbook

A placement needs shared responsibility.



Employers provide the conditions for interns to learn and contribute.

A. Design before recruitment

Start with work you can teach and supervise. Identify the business purpose, learning goals, suitable tasks, restrictions, schedule, resources, and an accountable supervisor. Confirm compensation and other arrangements through the appropriate review. Assess who may struggle to access the opportunity and what support can reasonably be offered.

A role should not depend on the intern already having the expertise the experience is supposed to teach. Do not recruit someone with “training provided” and then judge them against an experienced employee’s speed on day two.

Employer role-design canvas

Element	Decision to record
Business purpose	What useful need will this role support?
Learning goals	What two or three capabilities will be taught?
Work products	What suitable outputs can demonstrate learning?
Supervision	Who owns the placement, and who backs them up?
Training	What must happen before each task?
Boundaries	Which actions, data, areas, or equipment are excluded?
Access	What tools, transport information, or adjustments are needed?
Terms	What hours, location, compensation, expenses, and dates apply?
Feedback	When are reviews scheduled?
Reporting	What route exists beyond the supervisor?
Completion	What evaluation and next-step conversation will happen?

B. Build a task ladder

Progress through **observe > practice > contribute > improve > explain**. This is a proposed teaching sequence, not a certification framework. Progress depends on the task and demonstrated readiness; some activities always require direct supervision or may never be appropriate for the intern.

Stage	Example in customer operations	Evidence before progressing
Observe	Watch an authorized employee handle inquiries	Can describe the process and boundaries
Practice	Draft replies to fictional cases	Accurate drafts and correct escalation choices
Contribute	Prepare real drafts for required review	Consistent quality under agreed supervision
Improve	Propose an approved FAQ update	Understands policy, audience, and review needs

Stage	Example in customer operations	Evidence before progressing
Explain	Present lessons and a handoff guide	Can explain work and remaining limits

Avoid progression based solely on time served. A week on site does not automatically authorize a new task.

C. Use a manageable weekly cadence

At the start of the week, confirm priorities, expected outputs, training, and review times. During the week, provide a reachable contact and an early sample check. At the end, discuss work quality, learning, barriers, and the next step.

Suggested 20-minute coaching conversation: Four minutes for progress and evidence; five for one learning challenge; five for feedback and a demonstration or practice plan; four for next priorities; two to confirm support and follow-up. Adapt to the work. Do not postpone urgent concerns until the scheduled meeting.

D. Example eight-week placement plan

This is an adaptable example, not a promise that every placement needs eight weeks or can authorize the same work.

Week	Learning focus	Suitable output	Supervisor responsibility
1	Orientation and task boundaries	Role map and supervised sample	Access, safety, reporting, terms, initial goals
2	Clear communication	Task agreement and updates	Model quality and explain review steps
3	Reliable contribution	Reviewed work product	Check accuracy and adjust scope
4	Feedback and teamwork	Revision plus handoff checklist	Midpoint review and shared goal reset
5	Cross-functional understanding	Approved role interview summary	Arrange appropriate observation
6	Improvement thinking	Small idea proposal or mock-up	Review risks and approve any test
7	Career and evidence	Approved skills portfolio outline	Verify evidence and discuss pathways

Week	Learning focus	Suitable output	Supervisor responsibility
8	Completion and transition	Handoff and next-step plan	Final evaluation and access closure

E. Evaluate behaviors you actually taught

Use evidence, context, and a conversation. Avoid personality judgments or scores for enthusiasm, extroversion, social attendance, appearance, private circumstances, or being available after hours.

Proposed descriptive scale: Not yet observed; developing with guidance; demonstrated with agreed support; demonstrated consistently within role limits. This scale is a draft coaching aid, not a validated assessment or credential standard.

Capability	Evidence to examine
Communication	Clear updates, appropriate questions, documented handoffs
Reliability	Agreed commitments met or changes communicated early
Quality	Work checked against explained standards
Judgment	Permission boundaries respected; concerns escalated appropriately
Learning	Feedback applied and practice reflected in later work
Collaboration	Contributions shared and teammates treated respectfully
Initiative	Useful observations or suggestions within authorized scope

For each capability, record an example, support provided, the intern’s view, and a next step. If the intern never had an opportunity to demonstrate it, mark “not yet observed.” Do not turn missing opportunity into a failing score.

F. Build relationships without assigning unpaid emotional labor

A buddy can answer everyday questions; a mentor can explore career choices; a supervisor remains accountable for work and support. Make expectations explicit and provide time. Interns should not have to become the office entertainer to be included.

G. Define early-exit and concern procedures

Agree on who receives concerns, how immediate risks are handled, what happens if the usual contact is implicated, and how school or partner coordination works where applicable. Explain how a placement may change or end and how records, property, access, and outstanding pay questions will be handled. Have qualified professionals review the actual policy.

Protecting employers and protecting interns means creating safe, fair, accountable processes. It does not mean discouraging reports, asking interns to waive rights, or suppressing inconvenient information.

H. School and community partner coordination

Identify the partner's placement coordinator, learning requirements, permitted information-sharing, check-in schedule, emergency contacts, and escalation responsibilities. Verify school credit separately with the school. Parent or guardian involvement, permissions, work restrictions, and communication arrangements require age- and jurisdiction-specific review.

Jaime does not promise national internship placements. Licensed schools and local partners remain responsible for finding, vetting, and coordinating local placements unless Jaime expressly agrees to a defined local support role. This manuscript does not create a placement service or licensing agreement.

I. Value the person. Make room for what they bring.

An intern is still learning, growing, and exploring. This experience is not a declaration that one job, one company, or one industry must be their future forever.

Your job is to help them see more clearly: what they can contribute, what they enjoy, what they need to practice, and which opportunities they want to investigate next.

Value their questions. Value the skills they already have. Value the fresh perspective that comes from not knowing why a process has always been done that way. Then help them understand the context that makes an idea workable.

Give them projects they can own. Let them try to solve a real problem before handing them your answer. Bring them to an appropriate meeting and discuss it afterwards. Arrange suitable field exposure. Introduce the people whose work keeps your organization - and its network of contractors and partners - moving.

They may discover that being in the field suits them better than sitting behind a desk. They may discover the opposite. They may find a role neither of you mentioned during the interview. That discovery is part of a successful experience.

Mentor them. Teach them. Show them. Give them room to make appropriate decisions, learn from recoverable mistakes, and build evidence of growth. The more you help them learn and contribute, the better prepared they can become for a future interview - including one with your company when a suitable opportunity exists.

Their success might mean a job, further education, an apprenticeship, a different industry, more confidence, or a clearer understanding of the life they want. Help them define it, rather than defining it for them.

> **An internship should expand a person's view of what is possible - and give them practical ways to move toward it.**

Beyond coffee and copy runs

Everyone may occasionally help with ordinary shared work. The problem is an internship built around errands while meaningful learning remains behind a closed door.

If copying is part of a task, explain the process it supports. If event setup is necessary, connect it to logistics, planning, accessibility, and service. Then widen the work. Do not make proximity to the break-room coffeemaker the intern's primary career pathway.

Ask weekly: **What did this person get to understand, practice, decide, create, or improve?** If the only answer is "They were useful," examine the learning design.

J. Write an intern role, not a smaller version of an experienced employee's job

Customize the description to the learning stage, experience, relevant age-related restrictions, task requirements, and support available. Age alone does not tell you a person's ability. An older career-changing intern may be new to the sector; a younger intern may already bring valuable technical skills.

Verify applicable restrictions and required supervision through qualified review. This section provides design guidance, not a list of legally permissible tasks by age.

Job-description rewrite clinic

A vague or unsuitable expectation	A teachable intern responsibility
“Manage all social media independently”	Draft three posts from an approved brief, check sources, and submit them to the designated reviewer before publication
“Handle customer complaints”	Observe trained staff, practice fictional cases, and assist within explicit authority and escalation limits
“Improve operations”	Investigate one approved workflow, document observations, and propose a small improvement for review
“Must know every business system”	Learn the named approved tools through demonstrations, practice tasks, and supported use
“Work wherever needed”	Complete the listed suitable tasks; clarify new assignments with the supervisor before starting
“Be professional and proactive”	Provide agreed updates, ask clarifying questions, meet or renegotiate commitments, and suggest improvements within role boundaries

Employer workbook: My intern job description

Role title and learning stage: _____

Purpose in plain language: Who will the work help? _____

Three meaningful responsibilities: _____

Two or three skills we will teach: _____

Existing skills we invite the intern to contribute: _____

What we require at entry, and why: _____

What we will teach rather than require in advance: _____

Training, supervision, and task eligibility review: _____

Decisions the intern may make / decisions requiring approval: _____

Schedule, terms, equipment, and access support: _____

Feedback, reporting, and completion arrangements: _____

Reality check: Could a candidate explain what a normal week might involve after reading this? Could the supervisor actually deliver the promised support?

K. Give them a problem they can own

Project ownership: different people, shared clarity

INTERN	Investigate + propose	Practice + update	Revise + explain
SUPERVISOR	Define + authorize	Coach + review	Evaluate + support
TEAM / PARTNER	Share context	Confirm handoffs	Give useful feedback

Ownership grows within clear decision boundaries; the supervisor remains accountable.

Ownership needs a clear problem, a useful output, appropriate resources, decision boundaries, and a coach. It is not “Figure it out” followed by three weeks of supervisor silence.

Start with a problem small enough to learn from but real enough to matter. Let the intern investigate, ask questions, generate options, and recommend an approach. Resist solving it at the first sign of uncertainty. Ask what they have noticed and what they would try next.

The owned-project brief

Problem: _____

Who experiences it / why it matters: _____

Learning goals: _____

Expected output and quality criteria: _____

Information, tools, and people they may access: _____

Decisions they can make: _____

Actions requiring approval: _____

Budget, time, privacy, and safety boundaries: _____

Coach, checkpoints, and backup contact: _____

Test, review, and stop conditions: _____

Evidence they may later describe or retain: _____

Example: The same question, every day

A service team repeatedly answers the same five visitor questions. An intern receives an approved project to draft a clearer information sheet.

The intern may observe suitable interactions, interview willing staff, and use approved non-sensitive information. They choose the draft layout and compare alternatives against the audience’s needs. The supervisor checks content and approves any use. The intern does not change policies or publish independently.

The first version is too dense. Instead of taking over, the supervisor asks: “What does a visitor need to find in ten seconds?” The intern revises and tests the draft through an approved practice exercise.

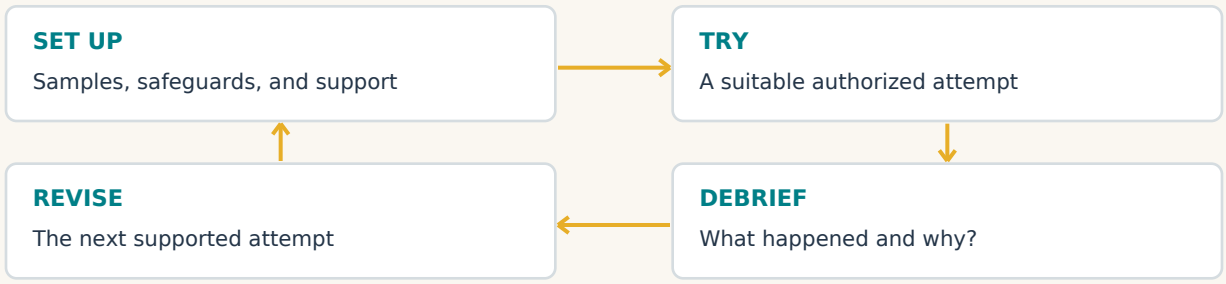
The result is both a useful work product and evidence of research, writing, judgment, feedback, and revision. The intern owns the project; the employer owns the responsibilities that cannot be delegated.

Coach with questions

- What problem are you trying to solve?
- What have you observed, and what are you assuming?
- Who else understands this process?
- What options do you see?
- What could go wrong, and how would we limit that risk?
- What is the smallest approved test?
- What support or decision do you need from me?

L. Let them try, revise, and thrive

Practice where mistakes are recoverable.



Learning does not require exposing people or customers to avoidable harm.

Learning includes mistakes. Choose practice conditions where a mistake is recoverable: sample data, simulations, reviewed drafts, mock presentations, and small approved tests.

Do not create avoidable safety, financial, privacy, customer, or safeguarding harm to teach resilience. “Let them fail” means allowing an imperfect first attempt within suitable safeguards - not leaving an untrained person alone with consequences they cannot manage.

The learning debrief

What did you expect? _____

What actually happened? _____

What did the attempt teach you? _____

What instruction, resource, or support was missing? _____

What would you change? _____

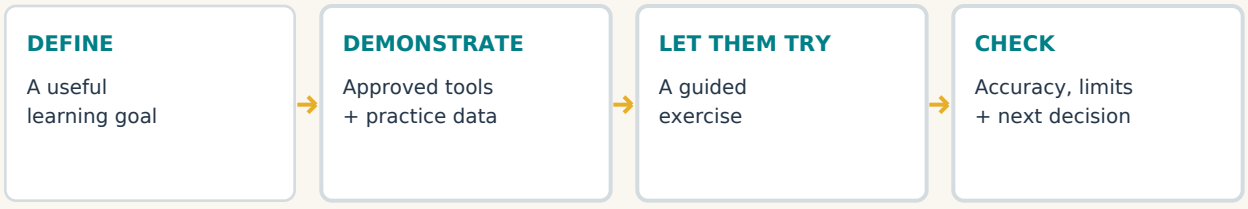
What is the next approved attempt? _____

A supervisor can say: “This version missed the requirement. Let’s understand why and plan the revision.” That is clearer and more useful than “Maybe you are not cut out for this.”

Notice improvement. An intern who applies feedback and knows when to seek help may be showing important readiness, even if their first draft was imperfect.

M. Let interns teach what they know - including modern tools and AI workflows

A skill exchange that works both ways.



Teaching time belongs in the work plan; adoption needs an authorized decision.

Learning can move in both directions. An intern may bring useful knowledge of digital collaboration, design tools, accessible content, automation, or approved AI-assisted workflows.

Invite them to show it. Do not assume every young person is a technology expert, or that experienced employees have nothing to contribute.

Pair the intern’s tool knowledge with employees’ process knowledge. Together they can test whether a workflow is accurate, appropriate, accessible, secure, and useful.

The 15-minute skill exchange

1. **Name the problem:** What task could become easier or clearer?

2. **Show the method:** Demonstrate using fictional, sanitized, or otherwise authorized material in an approved tool.

3. **Let someone try:** Provide a short guided exercise and an accessible alternative where needed.

4. **Check the result:** Compare with a known standard or approved manual process.

5. **Discuss limits:** Identify errors, restrictions, review needs, and situations where the tool should not be used.

6. **Choose the next step:** The authorized owner decides whether to investigate further or adopt anything.

Intern-led teaching plan

Skill or workflow I can demonstrate: _____

Business problem it addresses: _____

Approved tool and demonstration data: _____

Supervisor approval / qualified reviewer: _____

Learning goal for participants: _____

Steps and short practice exercise: _____

Accuracy checks and limitations: _____

Accessibility and support needs: _____

Feedback and next decision: _____

Example: An AI draft that needs a human brain

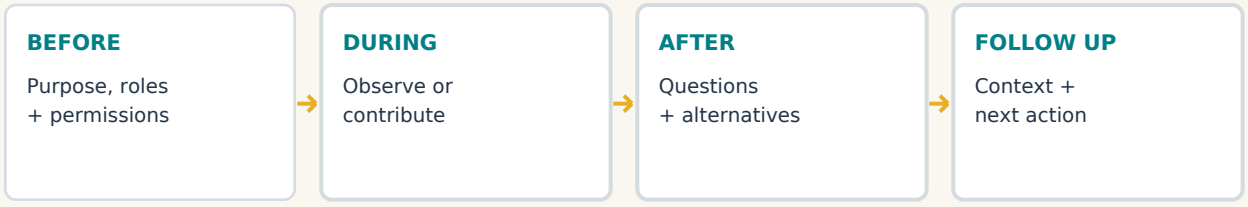
An intern demonstrates how an approved AI tool can suggest headings for a fictional meeting summary. A coworker notices that it invented an action owner. They check the output against the original notes and correct it.

The intern contributes tool knowledge. The coworker contributes process judgment. The team learns a workflow with verification instead of confusing a polished output with a reliable one.

Employer action: Give preparation and teaching time within the agreed work arrangements. Recognize the contribution. Do not turn one demonstration into indefinite unpaid technical support or make the intern accountable for deploying a system they cannot authorize.

N. Bring them to the meeting - and keep learning afterwards

Turn a meeting into a learning opportunity.



Choose suitable meetings and protect confidential information.

A meeting can reveal how people make decisions, manage uncertainty, collaborate, and handle tradeoffs. Without context, it can also sound like twelve acronyms having an argument.

Choose an appropriate meeting, confirm attendance and confidentiality, and explain the purpose. Tell the intern whether they are observing, taking authorized notes, asking questions, or contributing a prepared item. Do not make them guess.

Before the meeting

Purpose and decision being considered: _____

People, roles, and useful vocabulary: _____

What the intern should notice: _____

Participation and note-taking permissions: _____

Information that must remain restricted: _____

After the meeting: challenge the thinking respectfully

Ask the intern:

- What did you think the real problem was?

- Which idea was supported by evidence? What evidence was missing?

- Whose perspective did we hear, and whose might be missing?

- What tradeoff shaped the decision?

- What would you ask if we revisited it?

- Did you notice a possible improvement or a different approach?

Then explain context they could not reasonably know. Invite challenge without making it a loyalty test. You can disagree with their conclusion and still value the thinking.

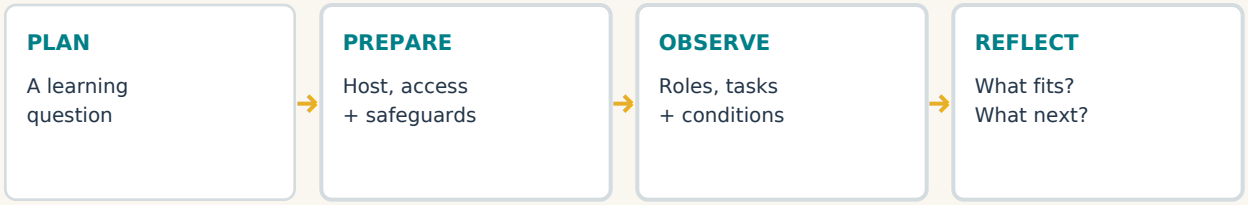
Workbook: My observation _____ / My question or alternative _____ / Context I learned _____ / One lesson I can apply _____.

Employer action: Close the loop: explain whether the idea will be considered, needs more evidence, or is not feasible. Do not expose the intern to confidential meetings simply to create

an experience.

O. Open the door to the field, the desk, and the roles between

Exposure can change the career question.



Observation is not permission to perform restricted work.

Many people choose a career from the small set of jobs they can picture. Help the intern expand that picture.

Arrange suitable exposure to departments, field settings, customers where appropriate, and willing contractors or partners. Explain how the work connects. A construction business may include planning, estimating, procurement, site coordination, skilled trades, finance, technology, and customer relationships. A healthcare organization may include clinical and nonclinical roles. A manufacturer may offer technical, operational, administrative, and commercial pathways.

These are exploration examples, not promises of access or permission to perform restricted work. Coordinate visits with the host and review suitability, accessibility, transportation, required permissions, supervision, protective equipment, and confidentiality. Do not send an intern into the field simply because someone has space in a vehicle.

Exposure planner

Experience	Learning question	Host and approval	Boundaries and support	Debrief date
Another department	How does this role use my team’s work?	_____	_____	_____
Suitable field observation	What does the daily work actually involve?	_____	_____	_____
Contractor or partner conversation	What pathways exist outside our company?	_____	_____	_____
Operations or planning discussion	How do decisions connect across roles?	_____	_____	_____

After exposure: let the intern reconsider

What I expected: _____

What I actually observed: _____

A role I did not know existed: _____

Tasks or conditions that appealed to me: _____

Tasks or conditions I want to investigate further: _____

Training or entry requirements to verify: _____

My next small exploration step: _____

An intern who says “I thought I wanted the desk role, but I want to explore field work” has learned something valuable. Do not treat a changing interest as disloyalty or confusion that must be corrected.

P. Prepare them for the next interview - and their definition of success

At completion, help the intern turn experience into accurate evidence. What did they own? What decisions did they make within their role? What feedback did they apply? What did they teach? What did they discover?

If a suitable vacancy exists, explain the actual hiring process and criteria. Offer a practice interview where feasible, without promising selection. Evaluate candidates fairly rather than equating access to extra unpaid opportunities with motivation.

If no vacancy exists, their learning still matters. Help them identify an appropriate next step and explain the evidence they may use elsewhere.

Shared future conversation

Intern: “Success for me currently means _____.”

Intern: “This experience helped me discover _____.”

Supervisor: “I observed you demonstrate _____ through _____.”

Together: “A useful next step is _____, with support from _____.”

Three evidence stories to prepare: A project I owned; a challenge I learned from; a contribution I made to the team. Use verified facts and authorized examples.

> **Help them become more capable, more informed, and more able to choose. The next chapter of their career may begin with you - or be stronger because of you.**

19. Cross-industry scenario lab

Use this lens for every scenario

FACTS: what do we know?

LIMITS: what may the intern do?

ROUTE: who must decide or respond?

LEARNING: what should change?

Use these fictional cases in a discussion, individual journal, or facilitated practice. They illustrate shared skills; they do not authorize tasks or replace sector training. Never require someone to reenact personal trauma. Participants may use a fictional role or observe. Serious misconduct scenarios belong in careful discussion, not comedy.

For every case ask: What do we know? What is missing? What can the intern do within their role? Who must decide? What should the employer change? What evidence would show a better outcome?

Case 1 - Manufacturing: “Just press the green button”

An intern is asked to operate unfamiliar equipment because the trained operator is busy. A coworker says the machine is simple.

Recommended approach: Do not operate it. Move to an appropriate safe location, notify the designated supervisor, and request the required training and authorization. Age restrictions and equipment rules must be checked by the employer. If pressure continues, use the alternative reporting route.

Employer repair: Ensure coverage and controls prevent untrained assignments. Explain who can authorize work.

Practice line: “I’m not trained or authorized on this equipment. I need the supervisor to confirm a safe task.”

Reflection: Why is willingness different from readiness? _____

Case 2 - Healthcare: A photo for your portfolio

An intern wants to photograph an interesting project, but a patient name is visible in the background.

Recommended approach: Do not capture or share the image. Ask the supervisor what approved, non-sensitive evidence may be used. If an image was already taken, promptly follow the incident process; do not improvise a response.

Employer repair: Provide clear photo, access, and portfolio rules before work begins.

Reflection: What could a fictional reconstruction demonstrate instead? _____

Case 3 - Hospitality: An angry guest

A guest demands a refund the intern cannot approve and begins shouting.

Recommended approach: Acknowledge the request, explain your authority limit briefly, and involve the authorized staff member. If there are threats or safety concerns, use the safety procedure. Do not promise a refund or tolerate danger to prove customer-service skills.

Practice line: “I understand you want this resolved. I’m not authorized to approve a refund, so I’m contacting the person who can review it.”

Employer repair: Train escalation, set authority limits, and ensure a reachable backup.

Reflection: What can you offer without promising an outcome? _____

Case 4 - Construction and trades: A shortcut to finish faster

A crew member suggests skipping a required protective step to save time.

Recommended approach: Pause the task and seek the site’s designated safety guidance. Do not debate a shortcut while continuing the activity. Review task eligibility and required

supervision with the employer.

Employer repair: Address production pressure, training, and supervision; reinforce that schedule pressure does not erase safety requirements.

Reflection: What response would show the employer means its safety message?

_____

Case 5 - Technology: “Can you test in the live system?”

An intern is given production access and asked to experiment with an unfamiliar change.

Recommended approach: Confirm authorization, testing environment, review, and rollback responsibilities before acting. Request a sandbox or approved practice environment. Access alone does not define permission.

Employer repair: Use appropriate access controls and a review process.

Reflection: Who should own the release decision? _____

Case 6 - Finance and administration: The number does not match

A reconciliation contains a discrepancy. A coworker says to use last month’s number so the report looks complete.

Recommended approach: Do not invent or silently change the figure. Record the discrepancy using approved methods and ask the responsible reviewer to resolve it. Escalate pressure to misrepresent information.

Employer repair: Define exception handling and protect accurate reporting.

Practice line: “I can document the mismatch, but I can’t verify that replacement number. Who should review it before submission?”

Case 7 - Nonprofit: The touching story

An intern drafts a donor post about a person receiving services. The story includes identifying details, but consent has not been confirmed.

Recommended approach: Hold publication and seek the approved consent and review process. Do not assume good intentions create permission.

Employer repair: Supply approved stories or clearly labeled fictional practice material and an authorization route.

Reflection: How can impact be communicated while preserving dignity? _____

Case 8 - Education and youth programs: A private message

A participant contacts an intern's personal account and asks to meet alone.

Recommended approach: Use safeguarding procedures and the designated supervisor. Do not arrange a private meeting or create an informal channel outside policy. If there is a disclosure or urgent concern, follow the applicable reporting procedure promptly.

Employer repair: Teach communication boundaries and relevant reporting obligations before assigning contact with children or vulnerable people.

Reflection: Which protections should be explained before the first interaction?
_____

Case 9 - Retail and logistics: Friendly pressure

An experienced coworker asks the intern to use their login because the coworker's account is locked.

Recommended approach: Decline credential sharing and contact the approved support route. Familiarity does not eliminate account or transaction risks.

Practice line: "I can help contact support, but I can't share my login."

Employer repair: Provide a workable backup procedure and explain accountability for account actions.

Case 10 - Marketing and creative work: The client dislikes it

An intern loves a design. The client says it misses the audience. The intern feels personally rejected.

Recommended approach: Ask which audience need is unmet, summarize the desired change, and revise a sample. Protect pride by separating creative effort from whether the output serves its purpose.

Employer repair: Give an audience brief, approval stages, and specific feedback.

Reflection: What question would move the conversation from taste to purpose?

Case 11 - Athletics and events: Familiar skills, new rules

A student-athlete intern is used to quick decisions under pressure. At an event, the intern changes a staffing plan without approval to solve a bottleneck. It creates an uncovered entry point.

Recommended approach: Notify the event lead, help restore the approved coverage, and learn the decision boundary. Athletic leadership skills can transfer, but the new setting has its own responsibilities.

Employer repair: Explain which decisions the intern may make and who coordinates changes.

Reflection: How can urgency be communicated without taking unauthorized control?

Case 12 - Remote work: The empty task list

The intern finishes assigned work and hears nothing for a day.

Recommended approach: Send a brief progress update, use the backup contact, and consult the agreed list of approved learning activities. Do not browse restricted records to appear busy or invent hours and outputs.

Employer repair: Maintain suitable tasks, response expectations, and backup supervision.

Reflection: What should have been agreed before the supervisor became unavailable?

Case 13 - Any industry: A joke that hurts

A coworker repeatedly jokes about an intern’s accent and says the intern is too sensitive.

Recommended approach: Use the designated reporting route; direct confrontation is optional, not a requirement. Keep factual notes through appropriate means and seek support. Legal coverage and next steps require specific review. See Source 3.

Employer repair: Respond through the conduct process and explain how retaliation concerns are reported. Do not substitute “they meant well” for addressing behavior.

Reflection: How can a workplace distinguish shared humor from humiliation?

_____

Case 14 - Any industry: No job at the end

An intern assumes strong performance guarantees a permanent role. The company has no opening.

Recommended approach: Discuss the actual possibilities early. At completion, request an evidence-based evaluation, an appropriate reference, and suggestions for next steps.

Employer repair: Explain conversion possibilities honestly from the beginning. Do not use vague promises to obtain extra work.

Reflection: What value can the experience still provide, and what should never have been implied? _____

20. Reusable workbook and quick-answer desk

Map your next working week

ONE PRIORITY + DELIVERABLE

TRAINING / HELP / APPROVAL

REVIEW POINT + DEADLINE

EVIDENCE + NEXT PRACTICE

Tool A - Shared learning agreement

Intern / employer / supervisor / backup: _____

Dates, location, hours, and compensation terms: _____

School or partner contact, if applicable: _____

Learning goals: 1. _____ 2. _____ 3. _____

Suitable work products: _____

Required training and access: _____

Restricted tasks and information: _____

Feedback schedule: _____

Reporting route and alternative contact: _____

Portfolio and information-sharing rules: _____

Review and completion dates: _____

Outstanding questions / owner / due date: _____

Use this to confirm understanding. It is not an employment contract, waiver, compensation classification, or school credit approval.

Tool B - Weekly planning page

Week of: _____

Priority	Deliverable	Reviewer	Due / checkpoint	Help needed
1	_____	_____	_____	_____
2	_____	_____	_____	_____
3	_____	_____	_____	_____

One skill I will practice: _____

One question I will ask: _____

One boundary or permission I will check: _____

End-of-week evidence and learning: _____

Tool C - Skill evidence passport

Skill	Task where I practiced	Evidence and permission	Feedback received	Next stretch
Communication	_____	_____	_____	_____
Organization	_____	_____	_____	_____
Problem-solving	_____	_____	_____	_____
Collaboration	_____	_____	_____	_____
Technical skill: _____	_____	_____	_____	_____

This is a reflection record, not an accredited credential or automatic certification.

Tool D - Mentor conversation page

Person / role / date: _____

Permission to schedule and available time: _____

Question about their daily work: _____

Question about entry routes: _____

Question about a skill worth practicing: _____

What surprised me: _____

Requirement I need to verify independently: _____

Thank-you or follow-through: _____

Tool E - Midpoint review

Complete separately, then discuss relevant work-related answers.

Intern: What am I learning? Where do I lack clarity or support? Which goal should change? What evidence shows progress? _____

Supervisor: What has been taught? What evidence have I observed? Have assignments matched the role? What support or access must improve? _____

Shared: Two priorities for the next phase; training or support needed; owners and dates; next review: _____

Tool F - Concern record

Date / time / place: _____

What I observed or experienced, in factual terms: _____

Immediate safety or support needs: _____

Relevant information retained through approved means: _____

Person or route contacted / date: _____

Response and expected follow-up: _____

Alternative or external support to consider: _____

Store this appropriately and share only with relevant people. Do not require a completed form before someone can report an urgent concern. Internal documentation is not a substitute for reviewing any external reporting deadline.

Tool G - Final shared evaluation

Learning goals reviewed: _____

Work products and examples: _____

Capabilities demonstrated with evidence: _____

Capabilities not yet observed: _____

Support that helped / support that was missing: _____

Intern’s perspective and any disagreement: _____

Next practice or learning steps: _____

Approved portfolio material: _____

Reference arrangements, if agreed: _____

Actual next opportunities, if any: _____

Tool H - First 30 days after the placement

Within one week: Update approved résumé evidence, send specific thanks, and organize permitted work samples. **Within two weeks:** Verify one pathway requirement and contact one appropriate learning or career resource. **Within 30 days:** Apply, enroll, arrange an observation, or take another concrete step matched to your situation.

My action / owner / date / support needed: _____

Quick-answer desk

The question	A practical starting answer
What if I have no idea what career I want?	Choose a question to investigate and collect evidence from real tasks.
What if I have no experience?	Use honest examples of learning, responsibility, and teamwork.
Can I ask about compensation?	Yes. Ask for clear written terms and seek appropriate guidance if unclear.
What if I finish early?	Update your supervisor and use only agreed next tasks or learning activities.
What if nobody explains the task?	Ask for purpose, output, example, deadline, and review point.
What if two people give different instructions?	Make the conflict visible and ask the designated decision owner to prioritize.
What if I am afraid to ask questions?	Prepare a specific question; ask how and when questions are best handled.
What if I make a mistake?	Pause further harm, report facts promptly, and follow the approved correction process.
What if feedback hurts?	Ask for a work example and a next action; seek support for humiliation or misconduct.
What if my idea is rejected?	Ask what constraint matters and what evidence would improve the proposal.
What if I am quiet?	Build relationships through preparation, thoughtful questions, and follow-through.
What if someone takes credit?	Describe contributions factually and request accurate acknowledgment.
What if I need an accommodation?	Ask for the designated process and share relevant information through that route.
What if I am asked to do something unsafe?	Pause the activity and seek the safety or alternative reporting route.
What if my supervisor is the concern?	Use the alternative contact or appropriate outside support.
What if I am missing pay or see incorrect hours?	Keep accurate records and raise the issue with payroll/HR or qualified guidance.
What if I want to use AI?	Check approved tools, data rules, verification, and disclosure expectations first.

The question	A practical starting answer
What if I need to miss a shift?	Use the attendance process as soon as reasonably possible and discuss coverage.
What if this career is not for me?	Record what you learned and compare a different next experiment.
What if there is no job at the end?	Seek an honest evaluation, approved evidence, and a concrete next-step plan.

Tiny glossary for the meeting that sounded like a different language

Deliverable: The output someone expects. Ask what format and quality are required. **Stakeholder:** A person affected by or involved in the work. Find out who they are. **Escalate:** Bring an issue to the person or route with authority to address it. **Scope:** What the assignment includes and where its boundaries are. **Handoff:** Passing work and enough context to another person. **Approval:** Permission from the person authorized to give it. A friendly comment may not count. **Bandwidth:** Usually time or capacity. The person probably is not asking about your Wi-Fi. **Circle back:** Revisit a topic. Ask when, so it does not become a circle nobody exits.

The human skills practice lab

These activities turn awareness, creativity, confidence, insight, collaboration, and team participation into things you can practice. They are proposed learning exercises, not validated psychological tests. Use fictional or non-sensitive material, offer an observer or written option, and discuss what happened without ranking personalities. Participation should not require personal disclosures, physical contact, purchases, photos, or a particular physical ability.

A useful rhythm is **notice > try > discuss > apply**. The activity is the beginning. The behavior you carry into real work is the point.

1. The story in my head

Builds: Awareness, curiosity, and better judgment. **Time:** 10-15 minutes. **Materials:** A fictional workplace scene or the example below.

You walk past a coworker who does not say hello. Your brain immediately writes a screenplay: “They don’t like me.” It casts you as the misunderstood lead and starts planning the sequel.

But the observation is smaller: the coworker did not respond. They may not have heard you, may be concentrating, or may be having a difficult moment. You do not know yet.

Try it: Read this fictional scene: “A teammate looks at a phone twice while you explain a task.” Individually write what you observed, your first interpretation, two other possible explanations, and a neutral question you could ask. Share only what you choose.

Example question: “Is now a good time to go over this, or should we find another time?”

Discuss: Which parts were facts? Which were guesses? What information would change your interpretation? How could assuming the worst affect your next action?

Workbook: Observation _____ / My first story _____ / Two alternatives _____ / A clarifying question _____.

Carry it into work: Before reacting to an ambiguous moment, name one fact and one question. For serious safety or conduct concerns, use the appropriate reporting route; this exercise is not a reason to dismiss concerns or invent excuses for harm.

Employer/team action: Model checking interpretations. Ask “What did we observe?” before attaching a character judgment.

2. Small talk, real connection

Builds: Confidence, listening, and relationship skills. **Time:** 15 minutes. **Materials:** A few optional question prompts.

Small talk can feel like standing at a conversational vending machine without the right change. You do not need an amazing opening line. You need a respectful invitation and genuine interest.

Try it: In pairs, choose a work-friendly question: “What is something new people misunderstand about your role?” “What tool makes your day easier?” “What is one thing you wish you had known when you started?” Each person gets two minutes. The listener asks one follow-up based on the answer, then summarizes one thing learned. Switch roles.

Do not turn every answer into your own story. Listen long enough to discover something you could not have predicted. People may skip a question or use a fictional role.

Discuss: Which follow-up showed you were listening? What made the conversation feel comfortable? How did you recognize when the other person wanted to finish?

Workbook: My opening question _____ / Their answer, without private details _____ / My follow-up _____ / What I learned _____.

Carry it into work: Have one appropriate short conversation this week and thank the person for something specific. Respect timing and a declined invitation.

Employer/team action: Make introductions and explain roles. Do not expect the intern to create all the connection alone.

3. Ten ideas before the eye roll

Builds: Creativity, curiosity, and collaborative problem-solving. **Time:** 20 minutes. **Materials:** Paper or an accessible shared document.

Choose a low-stakes fictional problem: new employees cannot find the correct meeting room. Your first idea might be a sign. Your second might be a map. Your seventh might be a tiny marching band. Keep the band in the brainstorm; it probably does not belong in the budget.

Try it: Spend three minutes generating ideas privately. Then take turns contributing one at a time, with an option to pass. Gather ten ideas before evaluating. In the next round, combine or improve two ideas. Finally compare options for usefulness, cost, accessibility, and risk. Choose one small test using practice materials.

Discuss: Did private thinking help more people contribute? Which unusual idea led to a practical improvement? Did someone dismiss an idea before understanding it?

Workbook: Problem _____ / My ideas _____ / An idea we combined _____ / Why we selected it _____ / Permission and test needed _____.

Carry it into work: Offer a small, evidence-informed proposal rather than changing a live process without authorization.

Employer/team action: Separate idea generation from evaluation. Explain constraints before a test and give a reasoned response to proposals.

4. The confidence ladder

Builds: Confidence through evidence and manageable practice. **Time:** 15 minutes plus a later practice opportunity.

Confidence often arrives after the action, which is mildly inconvenient when you were hoping it would show up first with snacks.

Try it: Choose one work behavior you want to practice: asking a question, giving an update, presenting an idea, or introducing yourself. Break it into three steps. For example: write a two-sentence update; rehearse it with a buddy; deliver it at an agreed check-in. Choose a realistic first step and the support you need. A written delivery is a valid option where appropriate.

Discuss: What makes the first step manageable? What evidence would show progress? How can the task stretch you without becoming a public performance test?

Workbook: Behavior _____ / First practice _____ / Next practice _____ / Real-work opportunity _____ / Support _____ / Evidence of progress _____.

Carry it into work: Complete one step and record what happened. “I asked a clear question and got the missing information” is stronger evidence than “I felt confident all day.”

Employer/team action: Provide safe practice and specific feedback. Do not equate confidence with volume, speed, eye contact, or extroversion.

5. Listen, sketch, clarify

Builds: Listening, clear instructions, feedback, and insight into misunderstandings. **Time:** 20 minutes. **Materials:** A simple abstract arrangement of shapes and a drawing surface; use a text-description alternative as needed.

Try it: One person describes a simple arrangement without showing it. Another recreates it. In the first round, use the initial instructions only. In the second round, allow clarifying questions and a halfway check. Alternatively, use an accessible text-formatting task and reconstruct a short fictional list.

Compare the results without awarding a “best listener” trophy. The point is to examine the communication system: unclear terms, missing orientation, assumptions, and the effect of a checkpoint.

Discuss: Which instruction could have meant two things? What question changed the result? Did the person explaining check understanding or assume it? What workplace task needs an early sample review?

Workbook: Ambiguous instruction _____ / Question that helped _____ / Better instruction _____ / Real task where I will use a checkpoint _____.

Carry it into work: Repeat an assignment in your own words and ask for an example before scaling up unfamiliar work.

Employer/team action: Use this to improve instructions, not to embarrass someone about hearing, language, drawing, or processing differences.

6. The handoff challenge

Builds: Collaboration, team participation, planning, and shared ownership. **Time:** 25 minutes. **Materials:** A fictional project brief and shared page.

A relay team can have excellent runners and still drop the baton. At work, the baton is often a file named “final_FINAL_reallyfinal2.”

Try it: A team of three or four plans a fictional welcome event. Assign a coordinator, information gatherer, draft creator, and reviewer; roles may be combined. Define the output, owners, deadlines, and handoff requirements. Halfway through, the facilitator introduces a change: the room is unavailable or the attendance estimate doubles. Replan without silently transferring work to one person.

Each handoff must include: what is complete, what remains, where the information is, the next owner, and the deadline. Have the receiver confirm understanding.

Discuss: Where did responsibility become unclear? Who noticed the change first? Did everyone have a meaningful contribution? Was the plan adjusted to available capacity?

Workbook: My role _____ / Input I needed _____ / Output I handed over _____ / Missing context _____ / Our revised plan _____.

Carry it into work: Use a short handoff note on the next shared task. Name the next owner rather than assuming someone will notice.

Employer/team action: Clarify decision authority and workload. Collaboration should not mean the most agreeable person absorbs every unfinished task.

7. Feedback remix

Builds: Insight, coachability, clear feedback, and creative revision. **Time:** 20 minutes. **Materials:** A fictional draft message or event notice.

Try it: Write a short welcome message for a fictional new intern. Swap drafts. The reviewer gives one specific strength, one audience-related question, and one suggested change. The writer summarizes the feedback, asks a clarifying question, and revises. Compare versions against the purpose - not personal taste.

Example: “Your greeting is welcoming. I could not find the start time. Could you put the time and contact person near the top?”

Discuss: What made feedback usable? Which comment sounded like a judgment rather than guidance? Did the writer understand the request before revising? Can you explain why you accepted or declined a suggestion?

Workbook: Purpose _____ / Feedback received _____ / Question I asked _____ / Change I made _____ / Why it helped _____.

Carry it into work: Ask for one concrete improvement and test it on a sample before redoing the entire assignment.

Employer/team action: Teach feedback as a shared skill. Do not treat public embarrassment as necessary preparation for the “real world.”

8. A day through another role

Builds: Perspective, empathy, cross-functional insight, and team awareness. **Time:** 20-30 minutes. **Materials:** Fictional role cards or an approved short role conversation.

Try it: Give each person a role in a fictional organization: customer service, operations, scheduling, finance, or the intern. A last-minute request arrives. Each role explains what they need, what they can offer, and what constraint matters. Build a plan that names the tradeoffs and the person who can approve them.

For a real workplace variation, arrange a willing colleague’s short explanation of their role. Observation or job shadowing requires the employer’s approval and appropriate privacy and safety controls.

Discuss: What looked simple from the outside but became complicated? Which role had an invisible dependency? How could earlier communication reduce pressure? What should be escalated instead of negotiated by the intern?

Workbook: Role explored _____ / A constraint I had not considered _____ / How my work affects that role _____ / One better handoff or question _____.

Carry it into work: Ask who receives your output and what they need to use it well.

Employer/team action: Show how roles connect. Keep responsibility for systemic problems with the people authorized to resolve them.

9. The invisible contribution

Builds: Appreciation, team awareness, and accurate recognition. **Time:** 10 minutes.

Try it: Think of a work contribution that made someone else's task easier: organizing the supplies, answering a clarifying question, checking accessibility, catching an error, or preparing a careful handoff. Write a specific thank-you describing the action and its effect. Share privately if appropriate; participation can remain written and unshared.

Example: "Thank you for checking the room instructions before the visit. It helped me arrive prepared instead of spending ten minutes negotiating with the wrong door."

Discuss: Which helpful actions get overlooked? Are we recognizing reliable work or only visible performances? Who tends to receive credit?

Workbook: Contribution _____ / Effect _____ / Specific thanks _____ / A habit I want to adopt _____.

Carry it into work: Give accurate credit in your next project update. Appreciation does not replace compensation, staffing, fair evaluation, or necessary resources.

Employer/team action: Recognize specific work without turning the exercise into a popularity contest or requiring emotional disclosure.

10. One small experiment

Builds: Self-insight, career curiosity, and confidence in taking a next step. **Time:** 15 minutes plus an approved follow-up.

Try it: Choose one career assumption to investigate: “I like planning,” “I prefer technical work,” or “I enjoy helping customers.” Design a small approved experiment, such as a fictional planning exercise, a role conversation, or supervised observation. Predict what you may enjoy and what may challenge you. Afterwards compare your prediction with the actual experience.

You are collecting clues, not signing a lifetime contract with a job title.

Discuss: Did you enjoy the task, the setting, or the people? What remains unknown? What evidence would help you choose a next step?

Workbook: Assumption _____ / Approved experiment _____ / Prediction _____ / What happened _____ / What I learned _____ / Next question _____.

Carry it into work: Bring one evidence-based career question to your mentor or supervisor.

Employer/team action: Offer feasible exploration without promising a vacancy, placement, credential, or access to restricted work.

Your weekly human skills page

Activity I tried: _____

What I noticed about myself: _____

What I learned from someone else: _____

One assumption that changed: _____

A behavior I practiced: _____

How it helped the work or the team: _____

One action to try next week: _____

Keep personal reflection private unless you choose to share it. Supervisors can discuss relevant work behaviors without collecting this entire page.

Visual direction for this review edition

The visual system uses clear workflows, decision maps, and branching pathways in BUILD6 navy, gold, and teal. Graphics make the lessons usable: choosing a help route, agreeing a project, checking feedback, sharing an idea, and exploring next steps. The writing retains its warmth and humor. Cartoon cast art is no longer part of the design.

These graphics summarize the nearby guidance. They do not authorize tasks, replace policies, or guarantee an outcome. Use the workbook to record your own decisions, evidence, questions, and next steps.

21. Publication and pilot review plan

What this draft establishes

A shared intern/employer foundation with embedded exercises, practical scripts, fictional scenario discussions, task design, coaching, evaluation, wellbeing, and career transition tools. The broad structure can support later audience-specific editions and sector supplements.

The positioning should promise help with the most important questions and a method for finding answers when a new situation arises. Do not advertise that one book resolves every industry's legal, technical, or human problem.

What must be added or verified before release

1. **Jaime's original source integration:** Review existing manuscripts, approved employer tools, and documented experience. Preserve originals. Do not invent author anecdotes or claim these fictional cases happened in Jaime's programs.

2. **Author voice review:** Have Jaime mark what sounds natural, what needs more humor, and where a personal story - with permission - would add depth.

3. **Reader testing:** Seek feedback from interns with different ages, education levels, access needs, and work experiences, plus supervisors, HR, and school/partner coordinators. Obtain appropriate permissions and avoid identifiable participant details in publication.

4. **Legal and operational review:** Validate the relevant jurisdictions and sectors for compensation, minors, work restrictions, school sponsorship, disability accommodations, discrimination, harassment, safety, workers' compensation, transportation, privacy, background checks, and safeguarding. The three sources below are starting points, not a full legal review.

5. **Industry review:** Ask qualified sector practitioners to review each supplement's tasks, restrictions, examples, and escalation procedures.

6. **Workbook testing:** Can readers complete the task agreement and idea proposal without extra explanation? Can supervisors use the cadence within actual workload? Which questions produce useful conversation rather than performative paperwork?

7. **Accessibility and design:** Test reading level, table usability, screen-reader structure, contrast, print writing space, and digital navigation. Create a designed edition after editorial changes stabilize.

8. **Publication and rights:** Confirm final title, legal owner, notices, third-party permissions, distribution rights, and any separate licensing terms. No automatic certification or credit claim.

Pilot questions and proposed measures

Use a small, consent-based pilot before asserting effectiveness. Proposed measures are not validated findings.

Question	Evidence to gather
Did onboarding provide clarity?	Intern can identify supervisor, reporting route, first task, and boundaries
Did tasks support learning?	Task agreements connect outputs to taught skills
Did feedback lead to practice?	Feedback log shows a next action and later work example
Did interns feel able to raise questions?	Voluntary confidential feedback about support and reporting access
Was supervisor workload workable?	Time estimates and qualitative feedback on the cadence
Did readers understand the scenarios?	Explain-back responses reviewed by appropriate practitioners
Did the placement end with direction?	Completed next-step plans and approved evidence records

Do not publish individual responses without permission. Do not score personal wellbeing or use participation in voluntary reflection as a performance criterion.

Proposed next products, subject to review

- **Intern Edition:** Expanded individual guidance and a generous write-in workbook.

- **Employer Edition:** Program design, supervisor practice, task libraries, reviewed policies, and implementation support.

- **School/Community Partner Edition:** Preparation, local employer vetting, coordination, monitoring, and locally reviewed responsibilities.

- **General Onboarding Adaptation:** Separate review for new hires; replace internship-specific terms, placement timelines, and school coordination. Do not simply relabel this manuscript as a complete employee handbook.

- **Industry Supplements:** Practitioner-reviewed scenarios, task ladders, vocabulary, and verified pathways for specific settings.

These are product directions, not approved prices, finalized licenses, or promises of national placement services.

Source notes

Sources checked October 13, 2026 UTC (October 12 evening, Eastern). Original teaching tools and fictional scenarios are editorial proposals. They have not been independently validated.

Source 1 - Compensation classification: U.S. Department of Labor, Wage and Hour Division, Fact Sheet #71: Internship Programs Under the Fair Labor Standards Act. Supports the limited discussion of federal for-profit internship classification in Chapter 2. The analysis is fact-specific; this draft does not apply it to any placement or resolve state requirements.

Source 2 - Safety and training: Occupational Safety and Health Administration, Young Workers: Employer Responsibilities. Supports the training and supervision emphasis in Chapter 4 and the employer section. Actual requirements and permissible tasks require workplace- and age-specific review.

Source 3 - Reporting and retaliation: U.S. Equal Employment Opportunity Commission, What You Should Know: What to Do if You Believe You Have Been Harassed at Work, and Retaliation. Supports the limited discussion of reporting options and protected activity under EEOC-enforced laws. Coverage, deadlines, and available remedies depend on the situation.

Closing note to the intern

You do not have to leave this experience knowing everything.

Leave knowing more about what you can do, what you want to learn, how to ask for help, how to contribute, and how to recognize an environment where people can grow.

Leave with evidence, relationships, and a next step.

And if you still occasionally forget someone’s name while confidently remembering their coffee order, you are probably having a very human beginning.

Land It. Learn It. Build What Comes Next.

More than an internship.
A better beginning.

The first job title should open possibilities - not close them.

The Internship Playbook brings real-world situations, approachable humor, practical conversations, and a workbook together to help interns contribute, grow, and explore what comes next.

For interns: build confidence, ask better questions, navigate feedback, share ideas, work with others, and discover pathways you may never have considered.

For employers: design meaningful roles, give projects appropriate ownership, mentor with intention, learn from the skills interns bring, and connect daily work to a wider world of opportunity.

Turn the experience into your next opportunity.

PRACTICE
Build skills through work

→

DOCUMENT
Keep approved evidence

→

REFLECT
Notice what fits your life

→

ACT
Choose one next step

Your next step may begin here - or be stronger because of this experience.

BUILD

DISCOVER PURPOSE. BUILD SKILLS. LAUNCH YOUR FUTURE.

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